

A DAILY PRACTICE COURSE

100

DAYS

OF PRACTICE

Practical Communication Skills

Ten minutes of theory. Twenty minutes of practice.
One skill a day, for one hundred days.

A COMPLETE SELF-STUDY WORKBOOK

100 daily lessons · 10 part reviews · 7 appendices of scripts and templates

Name _____

Start date _____

100 Days of Practical Communication Skills

A self-study course book with daily lessons, drills, scripts and review checkpoints.

How this book is meant to be used. This is a workbook, not a reader. Every day contains a short explanation and a practice task that must be done out loud, in writing, or with another person. Reading a day without doing the drill produces no measurable change.

A note on evidence and judgement. The frameworks here (active listening, PREP, STAR, DESC, non-violent communication, the rhetorical appeals, BLUF) are long-established tools from teaching, negotiation and professional training practice. They are starting structures, not rules. Culture, hierarchy, industry and personality all change what lands well. Adapt the wording to your own voice and context; keep the underlying behaviour.

Scope. This course covers everyday, professional and public communication. It is not therapy, and it is not a substitute for professional help with anxiety, trauma, a speech or language disorder, or a workplace situation involving harassment or safety. If any of those apply, seek the appropriate specialist alongside this practice.

Generated as a printable A4 workbook. Set your printer to double-sided, actual size.

How to Use This Course

The course is built on a single assumption: communication is a motor skill as much as an intellectual one. You already understand most of the ideas in this book. What you lack is repetition under mild pressure. So the structure is deliberately repetitive.

THE SHAPE OF A DAY

Focus	One sentence naming the single behaviour of the day.
Why it matters	The short version of the reasoning. Two minutes of reading.
Learn	Two to four concepts, each with the detail you need to apply it.
Practice today	The drill. Timed, specific, and mostly done out loud or in writing.
Say it like this	Ready-made language you can borrow verbatim until your own version arrives.
Watch out	The failure mode. This is where most people go wrong on this skill.
Journal	One question to answer in two or three lines before you close the book.

THE RHYTHM

- **One day at a time, in order.** The parts build on each other: listening before persuasion, breath before public speaking.
- **Twenty to thirty minutes.** Ten minutes reading, fifteen to twenty minutes practising. If you only have ten, do the drill and skip the reading.
- **Missed a day? Do not double up.** Just continue. A hundred lessons spread over five months still works. Doubling up turns practice into reading.
- **After every tenth day, stop and review.** A part review sits after each block of ten days, with a self-check, a consolidation drill and a five-point score. It is not a lesson day — add it to the tenth day, or take an extra day for it.

FOUR RULES THAT DECIDE WHETHER THIS WORKS

- 1. Practise out loud.** Silent reading trains nothing. Your mouth, breath and nerves need the repetition, not your eyes.
- 2. Record yourself weekly.** Sixty seconds on your phone. It is the only honest feedback available for free.
- 3. Use one real situation per day.** Every drill is designed to be dropped into work or life the same day. That transfer is the whole point.
- 4. Keep a written log.** Two or three lines a day. On Day 100 you will read it back, and the change will be obvious in a way that memory cannot show you.

The Daily Twenty Minutes

If you want a fixed routine, use this one. It fits in a lunch break and needs no equipment beyond a phone.

THE ROUTINE

1. **Two minutes — breathe and warm up.** Ten low breaths (four in, six out). Hum up and down your range. Say a tongue twister three times, slowly.
2. **Five minutes — read the day.** Focus, why, learn. Underline one sentence.
3. **Ten minutes — do the drill.** Out loud, standing if you can. Record it if the day asks you to.
4. **Two minutes — plan the transfer.** Name the exact conversation today where you will use it, and the words you will use.
5. **One minute — journal.** Answer the prompt in two or three lines. Date it.

WHAT YOU NEED

- **A phone** for audio and video recording.
- **A notebook** or a single running document for the journal and the drills that involve writing.
- **A practice partner, ideally.** A friend, partner or colleague who will spend ten minutes a week doing a role-play and giving you one honest observation. Roughly a quarter of the drills are better with a partner; all of them can be done alone.
- **A mirror or a laptop camera** for the body-language and delivery days.

IF YOU ARE SHORT ON TIME

Do the drill and nothing else. Twelve minutes of practice beats thirty minutes of reading every time. The reading is scaffolding; the drill is the building.

IF YOU ARE NERVOUS ABOUT PRACTISING WITH REAL PEOPLE

Start with the low-stakes half of every drill: read aloud, record yourself, rehearse in a mirror, write the script. Then use the language with a stranger you will never see again — a shop assistant, a barista, a neighbour. Strangers are the safest gym in the world, because there is no history to protect.

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Your 100-Day Tracker

Fill in the date as you finish each day. Ten columns, ten rows: each row is one part of the course.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20
21	22	23	24	25	26	27	28	29	30
31	32	33	34	35	36	37	38	39	40
41	42	43	44	45	46	47	48	49	50
51	52	53	54	55	56	57	58	59	60
61	62	63	64	65	66	67	68	69	70
71	72	73	74	75	76	77	78	79	80
81	82	83	84	85	86	87	88	89	90
91	92	93	94	95	96	97	98	99	100

STREAK NOTES

Three missed days in a row is the danger point. If it happens, restart with a five-minute version of the next day rather than trying to catch up.

PART ONE

Foundations: Awareness, Intent, Presence

DAYS 1-10

Most communication problems are not vocabulary problems. They are attention problems, intent problems and habit problems. Before you learn techniques, you need an honest picture of how you currently come across, and a handful of physical habits that make everything else easier: a settled body, a slower pace, fewer filler words and a clear purpose before you open your mouth. This part is the foundation the other ninety days sit on.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Describe your own communication strengths and two specific habits you want to change.
- State the purpose of any message in one sentence before you deliver it.
- Speak at a pace people can follow, with pauses instead of fillers.
- Stay physically calm and attentive in conversations that used to rattle you.
- Project both warmth and competence in the first thirty seconds of meeting someone.

DAY 1

DAY 1 OF 100

Take Your Communication Baseline

Focus: You cannot improve what you have never measured.

You already communicate hundreds of times a day, mostly on autopilot. Today you switch the autopilot off long enough to see what it is doing. A baseline gives you two things: a starting point you can compare against on Day 100, and a short list of specific habits to aim at instead of the vague wish to “be better at talking to people.”

LEARN

- **Communication is a set of separable skills.** Listening, structuring, voice, body language, writing and handling conflict are trained differently. Rating yourself on each stops you from writing off the whole area.
- **Recordings beat memory.** Your memory of how you sounded is filtered by how you felt. A sixty-second recording is objective and slightly uncomfortable, which is exactly why it works.
- **Two habits, not ten.** Improvement comes from a narrow focus. Pick the two habits with the highest cost to you right now.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Score yourself 1-10 on each of these eight areas: listening, clarity, brevity, voice, body language, small talk, writing, difficult conversations. Write the numbers down with today's date.
2. Record sixty seconds of yourself on your phone answering: “What do you do, and what are you working on right now?” Do it in one take.
3. Play it back twice. First pass: only note pace, volume and filler words. Second pass: only note whether the content was clear and easy to follow.
4. Write your two target habits as observable behaviours, for example “I say *um* about six times a minute” or “I answer questions for ninety seconds when thirty would do.”
5. Save the recording in a folder called *Day 1*. You will re-record the same answer on Day 100.

WATCH OUT

Do not delete the recording because you hate it. Almost everyone dislikes their first one. The discomfort is data, not evidence that you are hopeless.

JOURNAL

Which of the eight areas costs me the most in real life right now, and why?

DAY 2

DAY 2 OF 100

Decide the Outcome Before You Speak

Focus: One sentence of intent, chosen before you open your mouth.

Unclear speaking is usually unclear thinking arriving early. When you have not decided what you want the other person to know, feel or do, you talk in circles while you work it out aloud. Deciding your outcome first takes about eight seconds and removes most rambling at the source.

LEARN

- **Every message has three possible outcomes.** Know (information), feel (emotion or reassurance), do (an action). Name which one you are after; often you want two, rarely all three.
- **Write the one-line intent.** “After this conversation, my manager knows the launch will slip by a week and agrees to tell the client on Friday.” That sentence organises everything you say next.
- **If you cannot write it, you are not ready to send it.** This applies to messages, meeting requests and hard conversations alike.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. List the five most important communications you will have in the next two days: a call, an email, a meeting, a family conversation, a message.
2. For each, write one intent sentence in the form: *After this, [person] knows / feels / does [what].*
3. Circle the verb. If the verb is vague (“understands better”, “is aware”), rewrite it as something you could observe.
4. Before each of those five interactions today, reread your sentence once.
5. Afterwards, mark each one hit or missed, and note in one line what got in the way.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “The reason I wanted to talk is simple: I need a decision on the budget before Thursday.”
- | “I am not looking for a fix right now. I just want you to know where I am with it.”

WATCH OUT

Beware the hidden intent. If your real goal is to be seen as clever or to win, your words will chase that instead, and the other person will feel it. Name the honest outcome, then choose whether it is worth pursuing.

JOURNAL

Where did I speak today without knowing what I wanted? What did it cost?

DAY 3

DAY 3 OF 100

The Gap Between What You Say and What They Hear

Focus: Manage the four layers travelling inside every message.

You send words. People receive words plus tone plus your apparent view of them plus what they think you want. That is why “Can you resend that file?” can land as criticism. Once you know the four layers, you can check which one is causing the misunderstanding instead of repeating the words louder.

LEARN

- **Content:** the literal information. Usually the only layer the sender is thinking about.
- **Self-disclosure:** what your message reveals about your state. A clipped message says *I am under pressure*, whether you meant it or not.
- **Relationship:** what your message implies about how you see them. This is the layer that starts arguments.
- **Appeal:** what you appear to want them to do. If it is unstated, people invent one, and their invention is usually worse than the truth.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Take one message you sent recently that did not land well. Write it out word for word.
2. Analyse it in four lines: content, self-disclosure, relationship, appeal.
3. Identify which layer caused the trouble. It is rarely the content.
4. Rewrite it so the relationship layer is respectful and the appeal is explicit.
5. For the rest of today, before sending any message longer than two lines, ask: *what does this say about how I see them, and is my ask stated?*

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “I want to be clear about my tone: I am frustrated with the process, not with you.”
- | “To say what I am asking for directly — I would like you to own the follow-up.”

WATCH OUT

Short is not the same as clear. Extreme brevity strips out the relationship layer, and readers fill the gap with their own anxiety. Add six words of context rather than sending three cold ones.

JOURNAL

When did someone last misread my tone? Which layer did I leave to their imagination?

DAY 4

DAY 4 OF 100

Slow Down: Pace as a Clarity Tool

Focus: Speak at a pace your listener can process, not the pace of your nerves.

Nervous speakers speed up, and speed hides meaning. Most comfortable conversational speech sits between 130 and 160 words per minute; under stress people push past 190. Slowing down is the single fastest way to sound more competent, because it signals that you are not afraid of being interrupted.

LEARN

- **Pace is felt, not counted.** Your listener does not measure words per minute; they notice whether they had time to absorb your last point.
- **Slow the start, not the whole thing.** Deliberately slow your first two sentences. Your natural pace after that is usually fine.
- **Punctuate with breath.** A full stop should mean a breath. If you can say four sentences on one lungful, you are rushing.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Pick a 150-word paragraph from a book or article. Read it aloud while timing yourself; 150 words in about 60 seconds is a good target.
2. Read it a second time, deliberately 20 percent slower, breathing at every full stop.
3. Now speak for 60 seconds without notes on “what I did yesterday” and record it. Count your words afterwards.
4. If you exceeded 170, do it again and aim to say less content rather than compressing the same content.
5. In one real conversation today, slow your opening two sentences on purpose and notice how the other person responds.

WATCH OUT

Do not confuse slow with dull. Slow means fewer words per minute and more pauses, not stretched vowels or a monotonous drone. Energy stays high; the speed comes down.

JOURNAL

In which situations do I speed up? What am I trying to avoid by rushing?

DAY 5

DAY 5 OF 100

Breathe From the Belly, Speak From Calm

Focus: Support your voice with low, quiet breathing.

Voice is breath made audible. Shallow chest breathing gives you a thin, tight, higher-pitched sound and leaves you gasping mid-sentence. Low breathing steadies the pitch, carries the sound and calms your nervous system at the same time, which is why it works both before a presentation and during an argument.

LEARN

- **Low and slow, in through the nose.** Your belly and lower ribs should move; your shoulders should not.
- **Exhale longer than you inhale.** A longer out-breath is what actually lowers arousal. Four in, six out is a reliable ratio.
- **Breathe before you speak, not after you start.** Take the breath while the other person finishes. It buys thinking time and prevents the rushed first clause.

PRACTICE TODAY — 12 MINUTES

1. Sit upright, one hand on your belly. Inhale through the nose for four counts and feel the hand move outward. Exhale for six. Do ten cycles.
2. Now sustain a quiet “ahh” on the out-breath for as long as it stays steady. Aim to build toward fifteen to twenty seconds over the coming weeks.
3. Read a paragraph aloud, taking a low breath at every full stop. Notice that your voice sits slightly lower and steadier.
4. Practise the *pre-speech reset*: three low breaths before you enter a meeting, dial a call or hit send on something difficult.
5. Use the reset at least three times today in real situations and note what changed.

WATCH OUT

Do not over-breathe. Big, forced gulps of air make you light-headed and look effortful. Quiet is the goal; nobody should hear you preparing to speak.

JOURNAL

What does my breathing do when I am put on the spot? Could I feel the difference after the reset?

DAY 6

DAY 6 OF 100

Cut the Filler Words

Focus: Replace *um*, *like* and *you know* with silence.

Fillers are not a vocabulary flaw; they are a habit of avoiding silence. They cost you credibility in interviews, presentations and negotiations because they signal uncertainty and they blur the boundaries between your ideas. The replacement is not a better word. It is a short, deliberate pause.

LEARN

- **Fillers cluster at joins.** They appear when you start a sentence, when you change direction, and when you are searching for a word. Those three moments are where a pause belongs.
- **You must hear yourself to fix it.** Fillers are inaudible to their owner in real time. Recording is non-negotiable.
- **Trailing connectors are fillers too.** Ending sentences with “so...”, “but yeah...” or “and stuff” leaks authority just as badly as *um*.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Record two minutes of yourself explaining how to do something you know well: making coffee, backing up a laptop, getting to your office.
2. Play it back and count every filler. Write the number. That is your rate per minute.
3. Re-record the same explanation. Every time you feel a filler coming, close your mouth and pause for one beat instead.
4. Count again. Most people cut their rate in half in one sitting.
5. For the rest of the day, ask a friend or colleague to raise a finger whenever they hear your filler. The mild social cost accelerates learning.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| Instead of “Um, I think maybe we should, like, wait”: [pause] “My view is that we wait.”

| Instead of trailing off with “...so yeah”: “That is my recommendation.” [stop]

WATCH OUT

Do not swap fillers for a new tic: repeated “right?”, “obviously”, “basically” or a clicking pen. Silence is the target, and it will feel far longer to you than it sounds to anyone else.

JOURNAL

What is my personal filler, and at which of the three joins does it appear most?

DAY 7

DAY 7 OF 100

The Two-Second Pause

Focus: Use deliberate silence to think, emphasise and hold attention.

Silence is the most underused tool in communication. A pause before you answer signals that the question deserved thought. A pause after a key sentence lets it land. A pause instead of an interruption gives the other person room to say the thing they were building up to. People who pause are read as calm and senior.

LEARN

- **Pause before answering anything important.** Two seconds. It reads as consideration, never as slowness.
- **Pause after your headline.** Say the main point, then stop for two beats. The silence tells listeners that mattered.
- **Pause instead of filling their gaps.** When the other person stops talking, wait. Roughly a third of the time they will add the most useful sentence of the conversation.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Have someone ask you five questions about your work or your week. Before each answer, count two silent beats. Notice the urge to jump in.
2. Practise the *headline-pause*: say “My recommendation is that we delay the launch by one week,” then stay silent for two seconds before your reasons.
3. In three conversations today, when the other person finishes a sentence, wait two beats before you speak. Write down anything they added in that gap.
4. Once today, resist the urge to fill an awkward silence in a group. Let someone else take it.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “That is a good question. Let me think for a second.” [pause]

| “I want to give you a straight answer, so give me a moment.”

WATCH OUT

A pause with wandering eyes looks like confusion. Hold your posture and your gaze steady while you pause, or it reads as being lost rather than thinking.

JOURNAL

How did the two-second pause feel? Where did the silence produce something useful?

DAY 8

DAY 8 OF 100

Say Less: The One-Breath Answer

Focus: Answer the question, then stop.

Over-explaining is the most common professional communication flaw. It comes from wanting to prove you have thought about it. The effect is the opposite: your main point gets buried in the middle of a long answer, and the listener starts editing you in their head. A confident answer fits in one breath, and then invites follow-up.

LEARN

- **Answer first, evidence second.** Give the direct answer in the first sentence. Details only if they are wanted.
- **One breath is a real constraint.** If your answer does not fit in a single comfortable exhale, it needs a summary version.
- **Stopping is an invitation.** Ending cleanly hands over the turn and lets the other person steer toward what they actually care about.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Write down five questions you get asked often: what you do, why a project slipped, what you think of a tool, how your weekend was, what you need.
2. Write a one-breath answer for each, maximum twenty-five words, answer first.
3. Say each aloud on a single breath. Trim until it fits comfortably.
4. Use at least three of them today verbatim, then stop talking and count two beats.
5. Note which ones drew a follow-up question. That is the sign it worked.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"We will miss Friday by about a week. The database migration took longer than planned." [stop]*
- | *"I would not use it. It solves a problem we do not have." [stop]*

WATCH OUT

Brevity without warmth reads as cold or evasive. Keep your tone open and your face friendly, and offer the door: "Happy to go deeper on any part of that."

JOURNAL

Which question do I habitually over-answer? What am I trying to prove when I do?

DAY 9

DAY 9 OF 100

Presence: Actually Being in the Room

Focus: Give one conversation your undivided attention.

Presence is the rarest and most noticed quality in communication. Half-attention is visible: the glance at the screen, the answer that responds to the previous sentence, the nodding while composing your reply. People do not remember your words nearly as well as they remember whether they had your attention.

LEARN

- **Presence is physical first.** Devices away, body turned toward the person, feet still. The internal state follows the posture more often than the reverse.
- **Drop the internal monologue.** If you are rehearsing your response, you are not listening. Trust that you will find words when it is your turn.
- **Transition deliberately.** Take three breaths and name the shift between tasks: *that call is finished; this conversation starts now*. Presence collapses when you drag the last meeting into this one.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Choose one conversation today of at least ten minutes and make it device-free. Phone face down and out of reach, screen off or turned away.
2. Set an internal rule: you may not plan your reply while they are speaking. When you catch yourself doing it, return your attention to their face.
3. Turn your torso and feet toward them fully at the start. Hold that orientation.
4. At the end, silently rate your attention out of ten and note what pulled you away.
5. Repeat the transition ritual (three breaths, name the shift) before every meeting today.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Give me ten seconds to close this down so I can give you my full attention.”

| “I want to do this properly and I am half in another problem. Can we do it at three instead?”

WATCH OUT

Faking attention is worse than rescheduling. If you truly cannot be present, say so and name a time when you can. People forgive a delay; they remember being half-heard.

JOURNAL

How did the device-free conversation differ? What is my most common attention thief?

DAY 10

DAY 10 OF 100

Warmth and Competence: The Two Signals

Focus: Send both signals deliberately in the first thirty seconds.

People sizing you up are answering two questions almost instantly: *can I trust you* and *can you do the job*. Warmth answers the first, competence the second. Most of us lean naturally on one and neglect the other, so we come across as either pleasant but lightweight, or capable but cold. Both are fixable with small, specific behaviours.

LEARN

- **Warmth signals:** a genuine smile that reaches the eyes, using their name, an open posture, unhurried attention, small acknowledgements of their situation.
- **Competence signals:** steady eye contact, a settled body, a lower and slower voice, specific language, clear structure, no hedging on things you actually know.
- **Warmth first, then competence.** Leading with competence alone reads as arrogance. Leading with warmth buys you the attention in which competence can register.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Rate yourself: which signal do you under-send? Ask one person who knows you well; their answer is usually faster and more accurate than your own.
2. Write two specific behaviours to add. For example: *say the person's name in my first sentence* (warmth) and *state my view without "I might be wrong but"* (competence).
3. Rehearse a thirty-second introduction that carries both: a warm greeting, your name, what you do in one specific sentence, and a question back to them.
4. Use it once today, in person or on a call.
5. Afterwards, note which signal felt less natural. That is your training edge for the next ninety days.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"Marcus — good to meet you properly. I run the support team here; we handle about four hundred tickets a week. How did you end up in this role?"

Instead of "I am not really an expert, but maybe we could try...": "I have done this three times before. I would start with the data audit."

WATCH OUT

Do not manufacture warmth with compliments you do not mean. Insincere warmth is detected quickly and destroys trust in both signals at once. Curiosity is the safest genuine route to warmth.

JOURNAL

Which signal do I default to? What does my under-sent signal cost me at work and outside it?

CHECKPOINT

Part One Review

You now have a baseline, an intent habit, a slower and better supported voice, fewer fillers, a working pause, shorter answers and two deliberate first-impression signals. None of these are advanced. All of them are load-bearing.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I recorded a Day 1 baseline and saved it.
- ☐ I can state a one-sentence intent before an important conversation.
- ☐ My speaking pace is roughly 140-160 words per minute when I am calm.
- ☐ I use a low breath before speaking rather than after starting.
- ☐ My filler rate is measurably lower than on Day 6.
- ☐ I can hold a two-second pause without discomfort.
- ☐ I have five one-breath answers ready for common questions.
- ☐ I have had at least one fully device-free conversation.
- ☐ I know whether warmth or competence is my weaker signal.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Re-record the sixty-second answer from Day 1 (“What do you do, and what are you working on?”). Compare it with the original for pace, fillers and clarity. Write down the single biggest audible difference.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Pace and pausing

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Filler control

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Brevity

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Presence and attention

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Warmth and competence balance

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If any of these is still shaky, do not push on regardless. The fastest fix is repetition with recording: five minutes a day of reading aloud will keep improving pace, breath and fillers while you work through Part Two.

PART TWO

Listening That Changes Conversations

DAYS 11-20

Almost everyone believes they are a good listener, and almost nobody is. Real listening is effortful: it means holding your own response, asking the question that goes one layer deeper, and proving you understood before you argue. It is also the highest leverage skill in this book. People who feel heard become cooperative, honest and generous, often within a single conversation. This part trains listening as an active, visible behaviour rather than a polite silence.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Recognise which of the four levels of listening you are operating at, in the moment.
- Paraphrase someone's point accurately enough that they say "yes, exactly."
- Ask open and follow-up questions that get past the first, rehearsed answer.
- Name the emotion under someone's words without sounding like a therapist.
- Close any substantial conversation with a summary and agreed next steps.

DAY 11

DAY 11 OF 100

Listen to Understand, Not to Reply

Focus: Suspend your answer while the other person is still talking.

Most listening is really queue management: you wait for a gap while rehearsing your point. The other person can tell, because your reply arrives too fast and answers the wrong thing. If you stop composing your response, two things happen: you hear the actual content, and you look significantly more confident, because only people who are sure of themselves can afford to wait.

LEARN

- **Rehearsing is the enemy.** You cannot compose and comprehend at the same time. Choose comprehension and trust that words will arrive when it is your turn.
- **Curiosity is the mechanical fix.** Instead of “what will I say,” run “what do they mean, and what do they want from me here?” It occupies the same mental slot.
- **Listening is visible.** Stillness, eye contact, small nods and short verbal signals let the speaker know they still have the floor. Total blankness makes people speed up and over-explain.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Choose three conversations today. In each, set one rule: no composing your reply while they speak.
2. When you notice yourself drafting, silently label it “drafting” and return attention to their face and words.
3. Before you respond, take one breath. Then start with something that references what they said, not what you prepared.
4. Ask a partner to talk for two minutes about a problem they have. You may only nod and say “mm” or “go on.” No questions, no advice.
5. Afterwards, write down their three main points from memory, then check with them how accurate you were.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Keep going — I want the whole picture before I say anything.”

| “Let me make sure I have it all first. Is there more?”

WATCH OUT

Do not confuse listening with agreeing. You can listen completely, prove you understood, and then disagree firmly. Confusing the two is why people interrupt: they think silence is consent.

JOURNAL

When did I catch myself drafting instead of listening today? What triggered it?

DAY 12

DAY 12 OF 100

The Four Levels of Listening

Focus: Notice which level you are on and move up one.

Listening is not binary. There is a ladder, and most conversations happen on the bottom two rungs. Naming the levels gives you a diagnostic you can run mid-conversation: *which level am I on right now?* That question alone usually moves you up a rung.

LEARN

- **Level 1 — Ignoring.** Physically present, mentally elsewhere. Phone, screen, your own worries. Visible to everyone but you.
- **Level 2 — Waiting.** You hear words and mine them for hooks to talk about yourself or to counter. This is the default in most meetings.
- **Level 3 — Understanding.** You track their meaning and structure, ask clarifying questions and could summarise their argument fairly.
- **Level 4 — Empathic.** You also track what they feel and what matters to them beneath the content. This is where difficult conversations get resolved.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. In each conversation today, note the level you spent most of it on. Use a tally in your notes: 1, 2, 3 or 4.
2. Pick one Level 2 conversation and deliberately move to Level 3: ask a clarifying question and summarise before responding.
3. In one personal conversation, aim for Level 4: name what you think they feel and check it.
4. At the end of the day, count your tallies. Most people find seventy percent of their day sits on Levels 1 and 2.
5. Identify the one recurring situation where you are stuck on Level 2, and write why. It is usually time pressure or an old disagreement.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| Level 3: *"So the constraint is the budget, not the timeline. Have I got that the right way round?"*

| Level 4: *"It sounds like the frustrating part is not the extra work, it is being told late."*

WATCH OUT

Level 4 is not always appropriate. Naming emotions in a routine status meeting is intrusive and slightly odd. Match the level to the stakes and the relationship.

JOURNAL

What level do I default to at work? And at home? Why the difference?

DAY 13

DAY 13 OF 100

Paraphrase: The Cheapest Trust You Can Buy

Focus: Say their point back in your own words before you add yours.

A good paraphrase does three jobs at once: it proves you were listening, it catches misunderstandings before they become arguments, and it lowers the other person's defensiveness almost instantly. It costs one sentence. In conflict it is close to a superpower, because people cannot keep fighting someone who has just accurately described their position.

LEARN

- **Your words, their meaning.** Repeating their exact words is parroting and sounds manipulative. Translating shows comprehension.
- **Compress, do not expand.** A paraphrase should be shorter than what they said. If it is longer, you are adding your own material.
- **Always invite correction.** End with “have I got that right?” and mean it. The correction is the valuable part.
- **Paraphrase before disagreeing.** “So your concern is X. Here is why I see it differently...” makes disagreement survivable.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Use a paraphrase five times today, in five separate conversations. Keep a count.
2. Use this shape: “So what I am hearing is [their point in your words]. Have I got that right?”
3. Once today, paraphrase someone you disagree with *before* you state your own view. Note how they respond.
4. With a partner, have them explain an opinion you do not share for ninety seconds. Paraphrase it until they say “yes, that is it.” You may need two attempts; that is normal and useful.
5. Write down any case where your paraphrase turned out to be wrong. Those are the misunderstandings you would previously have argued through.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “Let me play that back: you are fine with the approach, but you need the client to hear it from you first.”
- | “So the real issue is not the cost, it is that nobody asked you. Is that fair?”

WATCH OUT

Avoid the therapist voice. “What I hear you saying is...” delivered slowly and solemnly makes people bristle. Say it in your normal voice, at normal speed, like a colleague checking a fact.

JOURNAL

Which paraphrase got the strongest reaction today, and what did it reveal?

DAY 14

DAY 14 OF 100

Ask Open Questions

Focus: Trade yes-or-no questions for questions that open a door.

The quality of what you hear is set by the quality of what you ask. Closed questions give you one-word answers and force you to keep carrying the conversation. Open questions hand the other person room, and they reveal the thing you did not know to ask about. This single change makes people describe you as a good conversationalist while you talk less.

LEARN

- **Open questions start with what or how.** “What made that difficult?” beats “Was that difficult?”
- **Be careful with why.** “Why did you do that?” often reads as an accusation. “What led you to that?” gets the same information without the defensiveness.
- **Avoid the stacked question.** Asking three things at once means they answer the easiest one. Ask one, then wait.
- **Do not smuggle in your answer.** “Don’t you think we should just delay?” is a statement wearing a question mark. People notice.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write five closed questions you asked recently. Rewrite each as an open question beginning with *what* or *how*.
2. Keep a list of five open questions in your pocket today: What is the hardest part? What would good look like? How did you get into that? What have you already tried? What would you do if it were entirely your call?
3. Use at least four of them today and note the length of the answers.
4. Practise asking one question and then staying silent for three seconds. Do not add a second question.
5. Catch yourself once asking a leading question, and rephrase it aloud as a genuinely open one.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “What would make this a good outcome for you?”

| “How are you thinking about it at the moment?”

WATCH OUT

Open questions in a fast operational meeting can stall it. When you need a decision, closed questions are correct: “Can you ship by Thursday, yes or no?” Use the tool that fits the job.

JOURNAL

Which open question produced the most surprising answer today?

DAY 15

DAY 15 OF 100

The Follow-Up Question

Focus: Ask a second question about their answer instead of moving on.

Most conversations stay shallow because we treat answers as items to be collected rather than doors to be opened. The first answer is almost always the rehearsed one. The second question is where the real information lives — and it is also the moment the other person decides you are genuinely interested rather than performing politeness.

LEARN

- **Follow the specific, not the general.** Pick the concrete detail in their answer and ask about that: a place, a number, a decision, an odd word choice.
- **Three questions deep is the target.** Statement, question, answer, question, answer, question. Very few conversations reach it and almost all of them are memorable.
- **Echo-plus-question is the easy form.** “Two years in Lagos — what was that like?” Almost no thought required and it works nearly every time.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. In three conversations today, commit to going three questions deep on one topic before you change subject or add your own story.
2. Practise the echo-plus-question form: repeat two or three of their words, then add “what was that like?”, “how did that go?”, or “what made you choose that?”
3. Notice the urge to reciprocate with your own story. Delay it by one question each time.
4. With a partner, have a five-minute conversation in which you may only ask follow-up questions, no statements. It will feel strange and they will talk more than usual.
5. Write down one thing you learned today that you would not have heard without the second question.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“You said it was mostly fine — what was the part that was not?”

“You mentioned you nearly left last year. What changed your mind?”

WATCH OUT

There is a line between interested and interrogating. Watch for shorter answers, a body turning away, or a glance at the door. When you see it, offer something of your own and let the pressure out.

JOURNAL

Where did the third question take a conversation somewhere I did not expect?

DAY 16

DAY 16 OF 100

Silence as an Invitation

Focus: Let the gaps stay open for three seconds.

The average listener leaves a fraction of a second between the other person stopping and their own voice starting. That small speed steals the most valuable material in the conversation, because people put their real point after a pause. Learning to sit in three seconds of silence is uncomfortable for about a week and then becomes one of your most useful habits.

LEARN

- **Silence pulls.** Human beings dislike an open gap and tend to fill it. If you do not fill it, they will, usually with something more honest.
- **Especially after a hard question.** Ask, then wait. Rescuing them with an easier version of your question guarantees an easier answer.
- **Non-verbal support matters.** Silence with attentive eye contact and a slight nod reads as *take your time*. Silence with a glance at your screen reads as *I am bored*.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Count three seconds in your head after the other person finishes speaking, in at least five exchanges today.
2. After asking your most important question of the day, do not speak until they do, no matter how long it takes.
3. In a group meeting, when a question hangs in the air, let someone else break the silence once.
4. Notice and record what people added in the gaps you left. Anything useful is direct evidence for the habit.
5. Try the *inverted* version once: when you have said something important, stop and let the silence do the work rather than adding a softening sentence.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Take your time.” [then wait]

| “I would rather have a considered answer than a fast one.”

WATCH OUT

Silence used as pressure in a negotiation is a tactic, and people who recognise it resent it. If your face is warm and your posture open, silence reads as space. If your face is flat, it reads as a squeeze.

JOURNAL

What did people say in the silences I left today?

DAY 17

DAY 17 OF 100

Reflect Feelings, Not Just Facts

Focus: Name the emotion under the content, tentatively.

People rarely state feelings directly at work, but they act on them constantly. A colleague arguing about a deadline may really be saying *I am overloaded and nobody noticed*. When you name the feeling accurately, the emotional charge drops and you can solve the actual problem. When you ignore it, you end up negotiating over the wrong thing for an hour.

LEARN

- **Tentative, not diagnostic.** “You sound frustrated” invites correction. “You are being defensive” starts a fight. Use *sounds like, seems, I might be wrong but*.
- **Guessing wrong is fine.** An inaccurate guess offered kindly still communicates that you are paying attention, and they will correct you with better information.
- **Use a real vocabulary.** Beyond angry and sad: frustrated, overlooked, cornered, uneasy, relieved, exposed, stretched, dismissed. Precision is what makes it land.
- **Do not follow with *but*.** “I can see you are annoyed, but...” deletes the acknowledgement. Let it stand alone for a beat.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write down eight feeling words more precise than *fine, annoyed or stressed*. Keep the list where you can see it.
2. Twice today, reflect a feeling you notice: “That sounds like it was frustrating” or “You seem relieved about that.”
3. Try it once in writing, where it is lower risk: “I imagine that was a difficult week.”
4. In one conversation, listen specifically for what the person needs rather than what they are describing. Write down your guess afterwards.
5. Note every case where your guess was corrected. The correction is a gift, not a failure.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“That sounds exhausting, honestly. Two launches in one month is a lot.”

“I might be reading this wrong — are you uneasy about the client, or about the timeline?”

WATCH OUT

Do not perform empathy. A reflected feeling delivered in a sing-song voice, or used as a technique to move someone toward your outcome, is transparently manipulative and damages trust more than saying nothing.

JOURNAL

Whose feeling did I name today, and what changed in the conversation afterwards?

DAY 18

DAY 18 OF 100

Listen for What Is Not Said

Focus: Notice omissions, hedges and hesitations, then ask about them.

The most important information in a conversation is often the part that was avoided. People signal it with hedges (“should be fine”), qualifiers (“mostly”, “in theory”), sudden vagueness, or a topic they walk past twice. Trained listeners catch these and ask one gentle question, which is how problems surface a week before they explode.

LEARN

- **Hedges mark uncertainty.** “It should be OK”, “probably fine”, “we think so” are invitations to ask what the doubt is.
- **Missing categories matter.** If someone describes a project and never mentions the client, the testing or a named colleague, the gap is the story.
- **Watch shifts in fluency.** People slow down, get formal, or over-explain around the thing they are worried about.
- **Ask about the pattern, not the person.** “I noticed we have not talked about testing” is safe. “You are hiding something” is not.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. In two conversations today, write down any hedge words you hear. Pick one and ask about it: “You said it *should* be fine — what would stop it being fine?”
2. In one meeting, note which topic nobody raised. Ask about it, framed neutrally.
3. Reread an email thread you are part of and list what is being carefully not said.
4. Practise the neutral probe: “What is the part you are least sure about?” Use it once today.
5. Record one case where the unsaid thing turned out to matter.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “What is the part you are least confident about?”

| “We have covered timing and cost. What have we not talked about that we should?”

WATCH OUT

Do not turn this into amateur mind-reading. You are spotting a gap and asking an open question, not announcing what someone secretly thinks. Confident interpretation of silence is how paranoia gets started.

JOURNAL

What was avoided in today's conversations? Did I ask about it?

DAY 19

DAY 19 OF 100

Take Notes Without Losing the Person

Focus: Capture the content while keeping the connection.

Notes protect you from the two great failures of listening: forgetting the commitment you made and asking someone to repeat themselves next week. But heads-down transcription kills the conversation. The skill is a light, visible, selective note habit that signals *this matters* rather than *I am processing you*.

LEARN

- **Announce it.** “Do you mind if I take notes? I want to get this right.” Almost nobody objects, and the framing raises your credibility.
- **Capture four categories only:** decisions, actions with owners, numbers and dates, and their exact words on things that matter to them.
- **Look up when they say something important.** Eye contact at the emotional moments, pen at the factual ones.
- **Close the loop within a day.** Send a five-line recap. This is where most of the value of note-taking actually appears.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. In your next meeting, use a four-box page: Decisions, Actions, Numbers/Dates, Their words.
2. Ask permission before you start writing.
3. Force yourself to stop writing and make eye contact whenever their tone changes.
4. Within an hour, send a recap of five lines or fewer, with owners and dates.
5. Compare your notes with what you remember. Note anything you would have lost.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Do you mind if I write this down? I want to get the details right.”

| “Let me read back the three actions I have, so we are agreed.”

WATCH OUT

Typing behind a laptop screen breaks eye contact and reads as multitasking, whatever you are actually doing. In sensitive conversations, use paper, or write nothing and make notes immediately afterwards.

JOURNAL

Did note-taking help or interfere today? What was in my recap that I would have forgotten?

DAY 20

DAY 20 OF 100

Summarise and Confirm Next Steps

Focus: End every substantial conversation with a thirty-second close.

The most common failure in professional communication is not misunderstanding during the conversation; it is two people leaving with different versions of what was agreed. Thirty seconds of summary at the end eliminates most of it. It also makes you the person who brings clarity to a room, which gets noticed quickly.

LEARN

- **Three elements:** what we decided, who does what by when, and what is still open.
- **Say the owner's name and the date aloud.** “Priya sends the draft by Thursday.” Vague ownership is how actions die.
- **Name the open questions explicitly.** Unresolved items that go unnamed reappear as surprises.
- **Then check it.** “Anything I have missed or got wrong?” Ten seconds; catches most errors.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Close three conversations today with a summary in this shape: “So: we decided X. You are doing Y by Wednesday, I am doing Z by Friday. Still open: the budget question. Anything missing?”
2. Do it even in informal conversations where you made a commitment.
3. Volunteer to summarise at the end of a meeting you are not running.
4. Write the summary down first if you need to; reading it aloud is fine.
5. Note any time your summary was corrected. That correction saved you a week.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “Before we finish, let me summarise so we leave with the same picture.”
- | “Two actions and one open question. Sound right to you?”

WATCH OUT

Do not summarise a conversation that was purely personal or emotional. “So, to summarise your grief” is a real mistake people make. Summaries are for work with actions in it.

JOURNAL

Which summary today revealed a difference in understanding?

CHECKPOINT

Part Two Review

Listening is now something you *do* rather than something you refrain from doing. You have a level diagnostic, a paraphrase, open and follow-up questions, deliberate silence, feeling reflection, an ear for omissions, a note habit and a closing summary. Together these will change more relationships than any technique in the rest of the book.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I can name the four levels of listening and spot my own in real time.
- ☐ I paraphrase before disagreeing, at least sometimes.
- ☐ I have five open questions I use regularly.
- ☐ I go at least two questions deep before changing the subject.
- ☐ I can sit in three seconds of silence without discomfort.
- ☐ I have named someone's feeling out loud this week.
- ☐ I notice hedge words and ask about them.
- ☐ I close important conversations with decisions, actions and open questions.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Have a fifteen-minute conversation with someone about something that matters to them. Your only goals: reach Level 3 or 4, go three questions deep at least once, reflect one feeling, and close with a summary. Afterwards, write down what you learned that you did not know before, and ask them how the conversation felt.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Holding my response

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Paraphrasing accuracy

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Question quality

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Comfort with silence

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Summarising and closing

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If listening still feels like effortful acting, the usual cause is that you are trying to do all eight behaviours at once. Pick one per week: paraphrase week, silence week, follow-up week. Layered habits stick; simultaneous ones collapse.

PART THREE

Voice: The Instrument You Already Own

DAYS 21-30

Your voice carries more of your message than your words do. Pitch, pace, volume, articulation and inflection decide whether you sound credible, warm, nervous or bored — often before your content registers at all. The good news is that voice responds to training faster than almost anything else in this book, because it is physical. Ten days of five-minute drills produces a difference other people can hear.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Speak from your natural pitch rather than a tight, raised nervous pitch.
- Articulate clearly enough that nobody asks you to repeat yourself.
- Fill a room without shouting, and be heard on a bad phone line.
- Use pace, emphasis and downward inflection to signal what matters.
- Warm your voice up in five minutes before anything that counts.

DAY 21

DAY 21 OF 100

Find Your Natural Pitch

Focus: Speak at the pitch your body wants, not the one your nerves choose.

Under pressure the throat tightens and pitch rises, which listeners hear as anxiety regardless of your words. Everyone has an optimal pitch — the note your voice makes when relaxed and well supported — and speaking near it sounds more resonant, is less tiring and reads as calm authority. Finding it takes about ten minutes.

LEARN

- **The hum test finds it.** Sigh out on “mmm” with no effort at all. The pitch you land on is close to your natural speaking pitch.
- **Support, not push.** Depth comes from breath and open throat, not from forcing your voice down. A forced low voice sounds fake and hurts.
- **Relaxation is the mechanism.** Jaw, tongue and shoulders. A clenched jaw raises pitch and flattens resonance instantly.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Sigh out loud three times on “ahh” with no attempt to control the sound. Then hum on the note that comes naturally.
2. While humming, say “one, two, three, four” keeping the same pitch. That is your baseline.
3. Record two versions of the same three sentences: one in your normal speaking voice, one starting from the hum. Play both back.
4. Loosen the jaw: let it hang open, move it gently side to side, then hum again. Notice the extra resonance.
5. Read a paragraph aloud starting from a hum, and notice where your pitch drifts upward. Those are your tension points.

WATCH OUT

Do not chase a “radio voice.” Artificially deep speech sounds performed, restricts your range and causes vocal strain. The target is your own voice, relaxed and supported.

JOURNAL

Where does my pitch rise? Which situations tighten my throat most?

DAY 22

DAY 22 OF 100

Articulate: Consonants Do the Work

Focus: Finish your words, especially the ends.

Most “I cannot hear you” problems are not volume problems. They are articulation problems: dropped final consonants, mumbled word endings and a lazy jaw. Vowels carry the sound; consonants carry the meaning. Tightening your consonants is the fastest way to be understood on a phone call, in a noisy room or in a second language.

LEARN

- **Endings first.** *goin* becomes *going*, *wan* becomes *want*. Final consonants are where clarity is won and lost.
- **Over-articulate in practice, normalise in performance.** Exaggerate hugely in drills; the residue in real speech is exactly right.
- **Slow the transitions, not the vowels.** Clarity comes from cleanly hitting the consonant joins between words.
- **Warm the mouth up.** Lips, tongue and jaw are muscles. Cold ones mumble.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Say these three times each, slowly and hugely over-articulated: “red leather, yellow leather”; “unique New York”; “the sixth sick sheikh's sixth sheep's sick”.
2. Then say them at normal speed, keeping every final consonant.
3. Read a paragraph aloud with a pen held gently between your teeth, then read it again without. The second reading will feel effortlessly clear.
4. Record thirty seconds of normal speech. Listen only for dropped word endings and count them.
5. Pick your three worst habitual reductions (*gonna*, *dunno*, *prolly*) and say each properly ten times.

WATCH OUT

Over-articulation in real conversation sounds condescending and slightly hostile. The drill is exaggerated on purpose; real speech should sound natural, just complete.

JOURNAL

Which words do I habitually swallow? Where does that cost me most?

DAY 23

DAY 23 OF 100

Volume and Projection

Focus: Fill the room with breath support rather than shouting.

Speaking too quietly makes people work to hear you, and listeners unconsciously discount speakers they have to strain for. Shouting solves the volume and creates a new problem: strain, higher pitch and aggression. Projection is different from both — it is directing a supported sound to a specific distance.

LEARN

- **Aim at a target.** Choose the person or wall furthest away and speak to them. Intention does most of the work.
- **Power from the belly, open at the throat.** Push more air, not more tension. If your throat aches, you are shouting.
- **Volume is a range, not a setting.** Being able to drop quiet and still be heard is more impressive than being loud.
- **Ask, do not guess.** “Can everyone at the back hear me?” takes four seconds and solves the whole problem.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Stand at one end of the longest room available. Say a sentence to the far wall, supported from the belly, without shouting. Repeat five times.
2. Practise three levels of the same sentence: one-to-one, small meeting, twenty people. Feel the change in breath, not throat.
3. Record yourself from across the room at each level and check what is audible.
4. Practise the *quiet-but-carrying* voice: half your normal volume, twice the articulation. Useful for making a room lean in.
5. In one real conversation today, deliberately speak ten percent louder than usual and notice whether anyone reacts. They will not.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “Can people at the back hear me clearly?”
- | “I will project a bit — stop me if I am too loud.”

WATCH OUT

If your throat hurts or your voice tires after twenty minutes, you are pushing from the wrong place. Return to the Day 5 breathing and build volume from air, not muscle. Persistent hoarseness deserves a doctor's opinion.

JOURNAL

Am I habitually too quiet or too loud? What does the feedback suggest?

DAY 24

DAY 24 OF 100

Vary Your Pace for Emphasis

Focus: Slow down on what matters, speed up on what does not.

A single unchanging pace flattens everything you say into equal importance, which forces the listener to do your prioritising for them. Most will not bother. Varying pace is how you tell people, without saying so, *this next part is the point*. It is also the difference between a monotone briefing and a talk people remember.

LEARN

- **Slow equals important.** Deliver your key sentence, numbers and conclusions slowly, with space around them.
- **Fast equals context.** Background, caveats and familiar material can move quickly. Speed here signals *you can relax, this is not the exam*.
- **Contrast is what registers.** It is the change of speed that creates emphasis, not slow speech in itself.
- **Numbers always slow down.** Figures, dates and names need extra space or they are lost.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Take a 150-word paragraph and mark it up: underline the three phrases that matter, cross out nothing but mark the rest as background.
2. Read it aloud with fast background and slow, spaced emphasis on the underlined phrases. Record it.
3. Read it again at one flat pace and compare the recordings. The difference is stark and it will surprise you.
4. Write one important sentence you will say today. Mark where you will slow down.
5. Use it for real, and note whether people responded to the emphasised part.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“We looked at three options, ran the numbers, checked with legal — and the answer is [slow] we should not do this.”

“The deadline [slow] is the fourteenth. [pause] Not the twenty-fourth.”

WATCH OUT

Constant variation is as monotonous as none. If every sentence swoops, you sound theatrical and untrustworthy. Choose two or three moments per five minutes.

JOURNAL

What is the one sentence in my most important message this week that deserves to be slow?

DAY 25

DAY 25 OF 100

End Sentences Downward

Focus: Drop your pitch at the end of statements.

Rising pitch at the end of a statement turns it into a question, and listeners read it as asking for approval. Doing it habitually — upspeak — undermines otherwise strong content, particularly for women and junior people, who are already more likely to be interrupted. A falling ending signals that the sentence is finished and that you meant it.

LEARN

- **Down for statements, up for questions.** That is the whole rule, and it is broken constantly under nerves.
- **Downward endings also stop interruptions.** A rising ending sounds like an unfinished turn, which invites people in.
- **Trailing off is the other version.** Fading volume at the end of a sentence has the same effect as upspeak; support the final three words.
- **Recording is the only reliable detector.** Almost nobody hears their own upspeak in real time.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Record yourself saying five statements: your name and role, a recommendation, a deadline, a price, an opinion.
2. Play it back and mark each ending: rising, flat or falling.
3. Re-record with a deliberate pitch drop on the last two words of each. Exaggerate it; it will sound normal on playback.
4. Practise the pair: “The deadline is Friday?” then “The deadline is Friday.” Feel the physical difference.
5. In one real conversation today, land three statements with a clear downward ending.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “My recommendation is that we postpone.” [falling]

| Instead of “So maybe we could try that? If that works?”: “Let’s try that. I will set it up.”

WATCH OUT

Do not overcorrect into a flat, heavy downward thud on every sentence — it reads as impatient or authoritarian. And genuine questions should still rise; the problem is statements dressed as questions.

JOURNAL

How often did my statements rise at the end? Which situations trigger it?

DAY 26

DAY 26 OF 100

Stress the Word That Carries the Meaning

Focus: Choose the operative word in each key sentence.

The same sentence carries completely different meanings depending on which word you stress. Most people stress randomly, or stress nothing, and let the listener guess. Deliberate word stress is the most precise emphasis tool available, and it costs nothing: you are already saying the words.

LEARN

- **One stress per sentence.** Stressing four words is the same as stressing none.
- **Stress = slightly louder, slightly slower, small pause before.** Not shouted.
- **The operative word is usually the new information.** Whatever the listener does not yet know is what deserves the weight.
- **Contrast needs the stress on the contrasted item:** “I said *Tuesday*, not Thursday.”

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Say “I did not say she took the money” seven times, stressing a different word each time. Note how the meaning changes completely each time.
2. Take three sentences you will actually say this week. Underline the one operative word in each.
3. Say each three ways: stress on the wrong word, no stress, correct stress. Record and compare.
4. Read a news paragraph aloud, choosing exactly one stressed word per sentence.
5. In a real conversation today, deliberately stress the operative word in your key sentence.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “*This is a pricing problem, not a marketing problem.*”

| “*I can have it done by Friday if I drop the report.*”

WATCH OUT

Stressing filler words (*so, and, the*) is a common nervous habit that makes speech sound randomly emphatic. Stress content words: nouns, verbs, numbers, names.

JOURNAL

Where has stressing the wrong word caused a misunderstanding for me before?

DAY 27

DAY 27 OF 100

The Five-Minute Vocal Warm-Up

Focus: Build a routine you can run before anything important.

Your voice is a muscular instrument and it performs badly cold. The first two minutes of any meeting are when first impressions form, and a cold voice sounds thin, cracks and sits too high. Singers and actors never skip warming up; professionals who speak for a living should not either.

LEARN

- **Order matters:** breath, then body, then voice, then words.
- **Humming is the safest warm-up.** It engages the voice gently and builds resonance without strain.
- **Do it somewhere private.** A car, a stairwell, a bathroom, a walk. Five minutes.
- **Hydration is part of it.** Room-temperature water twenty minutes before; caffeine and dairy immediately before are unhelpful.

PRACTICE TODAY — 12 MINUTES

1. **Breath (1 min):** ten low breaths, four in, six out.
2. **Body (1 min):** roll shoulders back five times, drop your jaw and wobble it, roll your neck slowly, shake out your hands.
3. **Voice (2 min):** hum up and down your range on “mmm”; slide a gentle “woo” from low to high five times; blow through loose lips for ten seconds.
4. **Words (1 min):** two tongue twisters, over-articulated, three times each.
5. Run the whole sequence once now, then use it before your next real call or meeting and note the difference in your first sentence.

WATCH OUT

Do not do vocal drills at high volume when your voice is cold or you are unwell. Gentle and quiet builds; loud and cold strains. If your voice is hoarse, rest it rather than warming it up.

JOURNAL

Did my first two minutes feel different after warming up? Where can I fit this in daily?

DAY 28

DAY 28 OF 100

Remove the Verbal Hedges

Focus: Cut the qualifiers that shrink your authority.

Hedging language — *just, sort of, I think maybe, does that make sense?, sorry to bother you* — is often invisible to the speaker and highly visible to everyone else. Each one shaves a little credibility off content that may be excellent. Removing hedges does not make you arrogant; it makes your certainty match your actual knowledge.

LEARN

- **Hedges signal permission-seeking.** “I just wanted to quickly ask” apologises for existing before the question arrives.
- **Distinguish real uncertainty from habitual hedging.** “I am about seventy percent sure” is precise and useful. “I might be totally wrong but” is a reflex.
- **Do not open with an apology.** Replace “sorry to interrupt” with “one thing before we move on.”
- **“Does that make sense?” puts the burden on them.** Use “What questions do you have?” or say nothing.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write your ten most-used hedges. Common ones: just, actually, sort of, kind of, I think, maybe, hopefully, quickly, sorry, if that is OK.
2. Search your last twenty sent messages for those words. Count them; the number is usually startling.
3. Rewrite three recent messages with every unnecessary hedge deleted. Read both versions aloud.
4. Practise the strong forms: “I recommend...”, “I need...”, “My view is...”, “I will...”
5. Go hedge-free in one written message and one spoken statement today.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| Instead of “I just thought maybe we could possibly look at this?”: “I would like us to look at this.”

| Instead of “Sorry, this is probably a stupid question...”: “I have a question about the assumptions.”

WATCH OUT

Politeness and hedging are not the same thing. Keep “please”, “thank you” and genuine acknowledgements. Cut the self-diminishing filler around your actual point.

JOURNAL

Which hedge is my signature? Whose presence makes me use it most?

DAY 29

DAY 29 OF 100

Sound Good on Phone and Camera

Focus: Adapt your voice and delivery to a compressed channel.

Phone and video strip out most of your nonverbal signal and compress your voice, so a delivery that works in a room lands flat online. You have to add back energy deliberately, articulate more, and structure more tightly — because your listener is distracted, on mute, and has three other windows open.

LEARN

- **Add ten to twenty percent energy.** What feels slightly animated to you reads as normal on camera.
- **Smile at the start of calls.** A smile is audible; on a phone call it is most of your warmth signal.
- **Look at the lens for your key sentences.** Looking at faces on screen reads to everyone as looking down and away.
- **Structure harder online.** Signpost, number your points, and stop more often to check in, because you cannot read the room.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Record a sixty-second video message on your laptop. Watch it on mute first: is your face doing anything? Then listen with your eyes closed: does the voice have energy?
2. Re-record with twenty percent more energy, articulating final consonants, looking at the lens.
3. Fix the physical set-up: camera at eye level, light in front of you not behind, mouth roughly a forearm's distance from the microphone.
4. Practise a phone opening: name, purpose, time needed. "Hi Sam, it is Alex. I need five minutes on the pricing question — is now OK?"
5. Use the lens-contact technique in your next real call for your two key sentences.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| "I will make this quick: three points, about four minutes, then I will stop for questions."

| "I am going to pause there — I cannot read the room on video, so tell me what is unclear."

WATCH OUT

Do not confuse energy with speed. Nerves plus a video call usually produces fast, high, breathless speech. Energy means engaged face and voice; the pace should stay moderate.

JOURNAL

What did I notice watching myself on mute? What did I notice listening with my eyes closed?

DAY 30

DAY 30 OF 100

Read Aloud: The Daily Voice Gym

Focus: Build a five-minute daily reading habit that trains everything at once.

Reading aloud is the single most efficient vocal exercise available, because it trains breath, articulation, pace, emphasis and inflection simultaneously, with the content already provided. Five minutes a day for a month produces an audible change. It is also the safest possible practice: there is no audience and no stakes.

LEARN

- **Choose good prose.** Well-written non-fiction, essays, speeches or high-quality journalism. Bad prose trains bad rhythm.
- **Read as if to one person.** Not a performance; a clear explanation to someone across a table.
- **Rotate the focus.** One day for breath at punctuation, one for final consonants, one for word stress, one for pace variation.
- **Record weekly, not daily.** Daily recording is discouraging; weekly shows real change.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Pick a text of about 300 words that you find genuinely interesting.
2. Read it once silently and mark it up: breath marks at full stops, underlines on operative words, brackets around fast background sections.
3. Read it aloud following your markings. Record it.
4. Read it a second time, thirty percent slower, and notice how much more control you have.
5. Schedule the habit: same five minutes every day for the remaining seventy days. Put it in your calendar now.

WATCH OUT

Reading aloud in a dramatic “performance” voice trains a voice you will never use. Keep it conversational; the goal is a better everyday instrument, not an audiobook career.

JOURNAL

When exactly will I do my five minutes of reading aloud each day?

CHECKPOINT

Part Three Review

You now have a pitch you can return to, cleaner consonants, projection without strain, deliberate pace and stress, downward endings, fewer hedges, a channel-adapted delivery for phone and video, a warm-up and a daily habit. Voice work compounds: the drills you keep doing will keep paying for years.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I can find my natural pitch with a hum in under a minute.
- ☐ I finish my final consonants when it matters.
- ☐ I can be heard across a large room without shouting.
- ☐ I slow down deliberately on my key sentence.
- ☐ My statements end downward, not upward.
- ☐ I choose one operative word per important sentence.
- ☐ I have used the five-minute warm-up before something real.
- ☐ I have cut my top three hedges from my speech and writing.
- ☐ I have a scheduled daily five-minute read-aloud slot.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Record a two-minute explanation of something you know well, applying everything from this part: warm up first, natural pitch, clean consonants, varied pace, one operative word per sentence, downward endings, no hedges. Then compare it with your Day 1 recording. Write down three audible differences.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Pitch and resonance

Articulation

Volume and projection

Pace and emphasis

Authority of endings

1	2	3	4	5
1	2	3	4	5
1	2	3	4	5
1	2	3	4	5
1	2	3	4	5

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

Voice is the most physical skill in the book, so progress is slower and more reliable than the rest. If little has changed, the cause is nearly always frequency: five minutes daily beats an hour on Sunday. Do the reading habit even if you skip everything else.

PART FOUR

Body Language and Nonverbal Signals

DAYS 31-40

Before you finish your first sentence, people have already read your posture, your face, your hands and where you are looking. Nonverbal signals are not a secret code and they cannot be read like a dictionary — but they do shape how your words land, and they are trainable. This part covers what to do with your body so it supports your message, and how to read others in clusters rather than in myths.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Hold a settled, open posture in meetings, presentations and on camera.
- Use eye contact at a rate that reads as confident rather than intense or evasive.
- Gesture purposefully instead of fidgeting, and keep your hands visible.
- Read other people's signals in clusters, and check your interpretation instead of assuming.
- Set up your camera, light and frame so you look present on video.

DAY 31

DAY 31 OF 100

Posture: Stand and Sit Like You Belong

Focus: Take up your own space without expanding into anyone else's.

Posture is the base layer of every other nonverbal signal, and it also changes how you feel. Collapsed shoulders and a lowered chin restrict your breath, raise your pitch and make you look apologetic; a settled, upright stance gives your voice room and reads as calm. It is the cheapest change available and you can make it in four seconds.

LEARN

- **Feet, hips, spine, chin.** Feet planted about hip width, weight even, spine long, chin level. Level chin is the detail most people miss.
- **Sitting counts more than standing.** Most professional communication happens seated. Sit forward, both feet down, forearms available on the table.
- **Stillness reads as authority.** Weight shifting, rocking and swaying leak nerves. Plant and stay planted.
- **Open, not expanded.** Occupying your natural space is confident; sprawling over a table or into someone's chair is dominance display and it costs you goodwill.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Stand against a wall with heels, hips and shoulders touching, chin level. Hold for thirty seconds. That is your reference.
2. Step away and keep it. Say three sentences aloud from that posture, then from a slumped posture. Notice the difference in your voice.
3. Set a phone reminder three times today: check feet, spine, chin. Correct in four seconds.
4. Sit and film yourself talking for sixty seconds from the side. Watch for rounded shoulders and a dropped chin.
5. Practise your *entry posture*: pause at the door, breathe out, level your chin, then walk in.

WATCH OUT

Military rigidity is not good posture. Locked knees, thrown-back shoulders and a raised chest look tense and restrict breathing. Aim for tall and relaxed, not braced.

JOURNAL

What does my posture do when I am uncertain? Where do I habitually collapse?

DAY 32

DAY 32 OF 100

Eye Contact in Threes

Focus: Hold eye contact for about three seconds, then move naturally.

Eye contact is the strongest connection signal you have, and the easiest to get wrong in both directions. Too little reads as evasive or nervous; unbroken staring reads as aggressive or strange. The reliable pattern is comfortable holds of a few seconds with natural breaks — roughly what happens automatically when you are genuinely interested.

LEARN

- **Three seconds, then break.** Break sideways or slightly down and return. Breaking upward reads as impatience or disbelief.
- **Listen more, look more.** Aim for more eye contact while listening than while speaking; thinking naturally pulls your eyes away.
- **In groups, one person per thought.** Deliver a full sentence to one person, then move to another. Sweeping the room continuously connects with nobody.
- **Culture and neurodiversity vary widely.** Sustained eye contact is respectful in some contexts and rude or difficult in others. Follow the other person's lead rather than a rule.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. In three conversations today, count three seconds of eye contact before breaking. Do it consciously until it stops feeling mechanical.
2. Practise looking at someone while they finish a sentence rather than looking away to prepare your reply.
3. In a group setting, deliver one complete sentence to each person you address rather than scanning.
4. If eye contact is genuinely uncomfortable for you, practise the alternative: look at the bridge of the nose or the mouth, which reads as attention without the intensity.
5. Note who you avoid eye contact with. It is usually about status or unresolved tension, not about eyes.

WATCH OUT

Do not count seconds in a real conversation for more than a day or two — mechanical eye contact looks like a hostage video. Use the drill to recalibrate, then let curiosity do the work.

JOURNAL

Who do I avoid looking at, and what is that about?

DAY 33

DAY 33 OF 100

Gestures Inside the Box

Focus: Use purposeful hand movement in the space in front of your torso.

Hands are either an asset or a distraction; there is no neutral. Purposeful gesture helps listeners follow structure, emphasises key points and makes you look at ease. Hidden or fidgeting hands do the opposite — audiences are drawn to movement and will watch your pen click instead of listening to your argument.

LEARN

- **The box.** Between your shoulders, from chest to waist. Gestures inside it read as natural; above the shoulders reads as frantic; below the waist is invisible.
- **Gestures should mean something.** Show size, sequence, contrast, or the number of items. Random hand-waving is visual noise.
- **Show your palms.** Open palms read as honest and non-threatening. Pointing at people reads as accusation; use an open hand instead.
- **Have a home position.** Hands loosely together at waist height, or resting on the table. Somewhere to return to prevents fidgeting.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Film sixty seconds of yourself explaining something. Watch it on mute and count fidgets: pen, hair, face, sleeve, ring, pockets.
2. Define your home position and practise returning to it after each gesture.
3. Practise three functional gestures: counting off three points on your fingers; showing a contrast by placing two options in different places in the air; showing growth or size with distance between your hands.
4. Re-record with the box, the home position and the three gestures. Compare.
5. Remove your favourite fidget object from reach in your next meeting.

WATCH OUT

Rehearsed gestures look worse than none. Practise the *type* of gesture, not the choreography. If you find yourself remembering when to raise your hand, you have over-planned it.

JOURNAL

What is my main fidget? What do my hands do when I am nervous?

DAY 34

DAY 34 OF 100

Your Face Is the Headline

Focus: Make sure your face is sending the message you intend.

People read faces first, fastest and most confidently. A concentrating face is easily read as an angry face; a neutral resting face is read as disapproval; slight tension around the mouth is read as disagreement. Most of us have no idea what our face does by default, which means we may be sending a message we would never say aloud.

LEARN

- **Eyebrows do the work.** A brief eyebrow raise signals recognition, interest and greeting. Its absence reads as indifference.
- **A real smile involves the eyes.** Mouth-only smiles are detected instantly and read as insincere. Think of something genuinely pleasant for half a second first.
- **Match your face to your content.** Delivering bad news with a nervous smile is deeply confusing and reads as callous. Serious content deserves a serious face.
- **Your listening face is a signal.** Small nods, brief eyebrow movement and responsive expression tell the speaker to continue. A blank face makes people over-explain.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Film thirty seconds of yourself listening to a podcast. Watch it. Most people are surprised by how flat or how stern they look.
2. Practise the greeting sequence in a mirror: eyebrow raise, eye contact, genuine smile, then speak. It takes about a second and a half.
3. Practise a genuine smile by recalling something specific and pleasant before you smile, then compare it in the mirror with a deliberate mouth-only smile.
4. Practise your serious face: level brows, still mouth, steady eyes. Use it for one difficult sentence today.
5. Ask one person you trust what your face does when you are thinking. Their answer is usually informative and slightly alarming.

WATCH OUT

Do not manage your face constantly — monitored expression looks stiff and uncanny. Aim to know your defaults, fix the greeting sequence, and match your face to serious content. Leave the rest alone.

JOURNAL

What does my resting face communicate? What did the person I asked say?

DAY 35

DAY 35 OF 100

Open Your Torso, Lower Your Shoulders

Focus: Remove the closed and braced signals from your upper body.

Crossed arms, a turned-away torso, hunched shoulders and objects held across the chest all read as closed, defensive or unavailable — even when you are merely cold or comfortable. You do not have to believe the interpretation to be affected by it. Since the cost of opening up is zero, it is worth doing deliberately.

LEARN

- **Point your torso at the person you are talking to.** Feet and chest aimed away signals that you are leaving.
- **Shoulders down and back.** Raised shoulders are a physical stress response; consciously dropping them lowers your pitch and looks calmer.
- **Stop using barriers.** Laptops, folders, mugs and crossed arms across the chest create distance. Put them down or to the side.
- **Lean in slightly at important moments.** A small forward lean signals engagement. A backward lean plus crossed arms signals judgement.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Notice every time you cross your arms today. Count it. Uncross and rest your hands on the table or at your sides instead.
2. Practise the shoulder drop: raise both shoulders to your ears, hold three seconds, release completely. Repeat five times. Use it before meetings.
3. In two conversations, deliberately square your torso and feet toward the person.
4. Remove one barrier in your next meeting: close the laptop, move the folder aside.
5. Try one deliberate slight lean-in when someone says something important, and notice their response.

WATCH OUT

Some closed positions are just comfort or temperature, and reading other people's crossed arms as hostility is a classic error. Manage your own signals; interpret others' only in clusters and in context.

JOURNAL

When did I close my body today, and what was happening at that moment?

DAY 36

DAY 36 OF 100

Distance, Angles and Where You Sit

Focus: Use space and seating deliberately.

Where you stand and sit changes the conversation before anyone speaks. Directly opposite reads as confrontational; side by side reads as collaborative. Too close creates discomfort that people attribute to you rather than to the distance. These are cheap, invisible adjustments with large effects, particularly in difficult conversations.

LEARN

- **Roughly an arm's length for professional conversation.** Closer for genuine intimacy, further for strangers and formal settings. Expectations vary substantially by culture and context.
- **Angles matter.** Ninety degrees or side by side lowers confrontation; face to face across a desk raises it. For hard conversations, sit at an angle or walk.
- **Choose your seat.** Next to the decision-maker for influence; opposite for negotiation; in the middle of a long table for visibility. Avoid the far end if you want to be part of the discussion.
- **Height creates status.** Standing over a seated person is a power signal. Sit down, or invite them to stand.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. In your next meeting, choose your seat deliberately and write down why.
2. For one difficult or sensitive conversation, choose an angle rather than directly opposite — or suggest a walk.
3. Notice one person today who stands closer or further than you find comfortable, and adjust rather than enduring it.
4. If you have a conversation with someone seated, sit down as well. Note how the tone changes.
5. Observe a meeting purely for seating: who sat where, who spoke most, and whether those two facts are related.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Shall we take this over to the sofa? Easier than across a desk.”

| “Let’s walk while we talk it through.”

WATCH OUT

Do not manoeuvre so obviously that it becomes the story. Seating games in a small team read as political. The most useful applications are lowering confrontation and being visible — not orchestrating dominance.

JOURNAL

How did the seating or angle change a conversation today?

DAY 37

DAY 37 OF 100

Steady Hands, Still Feet

Focus: Eliminate the nervous movement that undermines your content.

Nervous energy has to go somewhere, and it usually escapes through extremities: tapping feet, clicking pens, jiggling knees, drumming fingers, playing with hair or a ring. Listeners cannot help watching movement, and every unit of attention it takes is one your message does not get. The fix is not willpower; it is giving the energy somewhere legitimate to go.

LEARN

- **Ground the energy downward.** Press your feet into the floor. Isometric pressure burns nervous energy invisibly.
- **Give your hands a job.** Holding a pen still, resting them on the table, or one hand loosely holding the other stops the search for something to fidget with.
- **Remove the props.** Take the pen out of your hand, the phone off the table, the change out of your pocket.
- **Breathe out longer.** Most fidgeting is unspent adrenaline; a long exhale reduces the supply at source.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Film ninety seconds of yourself talking while seated, framed to include your hands and, if possible, your feet.
2. Count every fidget. Write the number down.
3. Choose a home position for your hands and a grounded position for your feet, and re-record.
4. Practise the isometric drill: while speaking, press both feet firmly into the floor for five seconds at a time.
5. Ask a colleague to signal you discreetly if you fidget in your next meeting.

WATCH OUT

Total immobility looks like fear too. The goal is purposeful movement with a still baseline, not a frozen statue. If you fidget because of a condition such as ADHD, channel rather than suppress: a discreet grounded fidget or standing up is far better than fighting your own nervous system.

JOURNAL

How many fidgets in ninety seconds? Which one is my signature?

DAY 38

DAY 38 OF 100

Mirror and Match, Subtly

Focus: Align your energy and pace with the other person's.

People relax around others who move and speak at a similar rhythm. When you match someone's pace, volume and energy, the conversation feels easy; when you clash — fast and loud against slow and quiet — both people feel subtly wrong without knowing why. Matching is not imitation. It is adjusting your dial toward theirs.

LEARN

- **Match energy first, then pace, then volume.** Those three matter far more than posture copying.
- **Delay and dilute.** Any postural echo should be slight and a few seconds late. Immediate copying is noticeable and creepy.
- **Match the register too.** Formality, humour and vocabulary. Being breezy with someone who is being careful reads as not taking them seriously.
- **Do not match hostility.** With aggression, deliberately mismatch: go slower and quieter. This is the one case where matching escalates.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. In three conversations today, spend the first thirty seconds noticing their pace, volume and energy before you settle on your own.
2. Deliberately adjust one dial toward them, and note whether the conversation felt smoother.
3. Practise a deliberate mismatch: when someone is agitated, respond noticeably slower and quieter. Note the effect.
4. Match register in writing too: reply to a formal email formally and a two-word message briefly.
5. Find one relationship where you habitually clash on rhythm, and write down which dial is different.

WATCH OUT

Copying posture and gestures as a technique is the fastest way to look manipulative, and most people notice within a minute. Stay with energy, pace and register; leave the limb mirroring alone.

JOURNAL

Whose rhythm do I clash with most? Which dial is the problem?

DAY 39

DAY 39 OF 100

Read Signals in Clusters, Not Singles

Focus: Interpret groups of signals, in context, and check your reading.

Popular body-language advice is mostly wrong: no single gesture reliably means one thing. Crossed arms may mean cold. Broken eye contact may mean thinking. What is useful is noticing a *cluster* of signals and a *change* from someone's baseline, then treating your interpretation as a hypothesis you check out loud.

LEARN

- **Baseline first.** You cannot read a change without knowing someone's normal. Quiet people are not disengaged; they are quiet.
- **Clusters, not singles.** Turning away plus shorter answers plus checking the time is meaningful. Any one of them alone is not.
- **Changes are the signal.** The moment someone's behaviour shifts is worth noting, along with what was being discussed at that moment.
- **Check, do not conclude.** "I might be misreading this — do you have reservations?" Asking beats guessing every single time.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Pick one colleague and describe their baseline in three lines: normal energy, normal amount of talking, normal expressiveness.
2. In your next meeting, note one moment when someone's behaviour changed, and what was under discussion.
3. Form a hypothesis, then check it with a question rather than acting on it.
4. Practise the checking sentence: "You went quiet when I mentioned the timeline — what is your read?" Use it once today.
5. Write down one case where you were wrong about what someone's behaviour meant.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | "I may be reading too much into this, but you seemed hesitant about the deadline. What is your view?"
- | "You have gone quiet. Is that thinking, or disagreement?"

WATCH OUT

Confident body-language interpretation is a genuine hazard: it produces false certainty about other people's inner states, and it fuels office paranoia. Treat every reading as a question, never a conclusion.

JOURNAL

What did I misread this week? What did checking it out loud reveal?

DAY 40

DAY 40 OF 100

Virtual Presence: Camera, Light, Frame

Focus: Set up so that the version of you on screen is the one you intend.

On video you are a small rectangle competing with notifications and other windows. Bad framing, backlighting or a camera pointing up at the ceiling will undo excellent content. Fixing the physical set-up is a one-time job that improves every call you ever make, and it takes about twenty minutes.

LEARN

- **Camera at eye level.** Raise your laptop on books. A low camera looks up your nose and reads as sloppy; eye level reads as being in the room.
- **Light in front, not behind.** A window or lamp facing you. A bright window behind you turns you into a silhouette.
- **Frame from mid-chest with a little headroom.** Include your shoulders and, ideally, your hands. Gesture where the camera can see it.
- **Audio beats video.** People forgive a grainy picture and abandon a call with bad sound. Wired headphones with a microphone are usually the cheapest large improvement.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Set up your permanent position: camera at eye level, light in front, background tidy and uncluttered.
2. Record a sixty-second video in that set-up. Check the frame: eyes about a third from the top, shoulders visible.
3. Test your microphone options and pick the best one. Listen to both recordings on headphones.
4. Practise gesturing within camera view rather than below the frame.
5. Write a short pre-call checklist and put it where you will see it: light, level, frame, mute state, notifications off.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “I am going to keep my camera on and my notifications off — I would rather be properly present for this.”
- | “Give me ten seconds to sort my light out so you are not talking to a shadow.”

WATCH OUT

Elaborate virtual backgrounds, filters and ring lights pointed straight at your face all draw attention to the set-up instead of to you. Aim for unremarkable and clear.

JOURNAL

What is the one change to my video set-up that made the biggest difference?

CHECKPOINT

Part Four Review

Your body now supports your message rather than contradicting it: settled posture, calibrated eye contact, purposeful gestures, a face that matches your content, an open upper body, deliberate use of space, less nervous movement, matched energy, careful reading of others, and a video set-up that does not work against you.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I can reset my posture in four seconds and I do it before meetings.
- ☐ My eye contact is comfortable in both directions.
- ☐ I have a home position for my hands and I know my main fidget.
- ☐ I have seen my own listening face on video.
- ☐ I notice and uncross closed positions.
- ☐ I choose my seat and angle deliberately for important conversations.
- ☐ I match energy and pace, and deliberately mismatch aggression.
- ☐ I check my interpretations of others rather than concluding.
- ☐ My camera is at eye level with light in front of me.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Record a three-minute video of yourself explaining a recommendation, in your real video set-up. Watch it three times: once on mute for body and face, once with eyes closed for voice, once normally for content. Write one specific fix for each pass, then re-record with all three applied.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Posture and stillness

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Eye contact

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Gesture and hands

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Facial expression

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Virtual presence

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

Body language is the hardest area to self-assess, so if you are unsure, the answer is more video. Two minutes of footage tells you more than an hour of reflection. If watching yourself is unbearable, watch it on mute first; it is far easier and still informative.

PART FIVE

Clarity: Getting to the Point

DAYS 41-50

Being understood quickly is the most commercially valuable communication skill there is. It is also the rarest, because clarity requires you to decide what matters before you speak instead of thinking aloud and hoping the listener keeps up. This part gives you a set of reusable structures — headline first, PREP, the rule of three, STAR — plus the editing habits that cut your word count in half without losing meaning.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Lead with your conclusion instead of building up to it.
- Answer any question in sixty structured seconds using PREP.
- Replace jargon and abstraction with plain, concrete language.
- Tell a work story in ninety seconds with a beginning, a middle and a point.
- Give a thirty-second version of anything you are working on.

DAY 41

DAY 41 OF 100

Lead With the Headline

Focus: Put your conclusion in the first sentence.

Most people tell the story in the order they discovered it: background, investigation, complication, and eventually the point. Listeners want the reverse. They need to know the conclusion first so they can decide how much attention to give the detail. Leading with the headline — sometimes called bottom line up front — is the single highest-impact change in this book for professional credibility.

LEARN

- **One sentence, no preamble.** “We should delay the launch by a week.” Then the reasons, in descending order of importance.
- **Cut the run-up.** “So, as you know, back in March we started looking at...” contains no information. Delete it.
- **Detail becomes optional.** With the conclusion known, listeners can ask for exactly the detail they want instead of waiting through all of it.
- **It works in writing too.** First line of the email, first line of the message, first slide of the deck.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Take three things you need to communicate this week. Write the headline sentence for each: the conclusion, decision or ask, in under twenty words.
2. Under each, list your supporting points in descending order of importance. Notice how the last one is usually unnecessary.
3. Rewrite one email you already sent so the first line carries the point.
4. Practise saying each headline aloud, then stopping. Resist the urge to add the run-up.
5. Use one headline-first opening in a real conversation today and note how quickly the other person engaged.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “Short version: the migration will slip to the twentieth. Three reasons, and one decision I need from you.”
- | “I am recommending we do not renew. Happy to walk through the numbers if useful.”

WATCH OUT

Headline first is not right for every situation. Emotionally difficult news to a person, or a conclusion that will be rejected outright without context, may need a sentence of framing first. But default to headline first, and make exceptions consciously.

JOURNAL

Which message did I bury the point in this week? What was the headline?

DAY 42

DAY 42 OF 100

PREP: The Sixty-Second Answer

Focus: Structure any answer as Point, Reason, Example, Point.

The reason people ramble when asked for an opinion is not lack of knowledge; it is lack of a container. PREP is the simplest container that exists, it fits in one minute, and it works for interviews, meetings, presentations and arguments. Once it is automatic, you can answer almost any question coherently with no preparation at all.

LEARN

- **Point.** Your answer in one sentence. Direct, no hedging.
- **Reason.** Why you hold that view. One or two reasons, not five.
- **Example.** A specific case, number or story. This is what makes it credible and memorable.
- **Point.** Restate the answer in slightly different words. This is what listeners remember, and it stops you trailing off.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write a PREP answer to: “What do you think we should do about X?” using a real current question at work.
2. Say it aloud and time it. Target: forty-five to seventy-five seconds.
3. Do three more, cold, on questions a colleague asks you often. Speak them rather than writing them.
4. Practise the transitions out loud: “My view is... The reason is... For example... So on balance...”
5. Use PREP for real at least once today, and note whether anyone asked a follow-up question rather than looking confused.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“We should hire a contractor. [point] We have four weeks and no spare capacity. [reason] We did exactly this in March and it cost less than the delay would have. [example] So: contractor, and I would start the search this week. [point]”

WATCH OUT

Do not announce the framework. Saying “I will use PREP here” is jarring; the structure should be invisible. And keep the example genuinely short — a two-minute example breaks the whole shape.

JOURNAL

Which question do I get asked repeatedly? What is my PREP answer to it?

DAY 43

DAY 43 OF 100

The Rule of Three

Focus: Group your points in threes.

Three is the number of items people can hold effortlessly, remember afterwards and repeat to someone else. Two feels incomplete; five overwhelms and nothing survives. Announcing three points also does something useful for you: it forces you to decide what matters, and it tells the listener how long they need to pay attention.

LEARN

- **Announce the number, then deliver it.** “Three things.” Then three, not four.
- **Signpost between them.** “First... second... and the third, which matters most...”
- **Order for effect.** Strongest first if attention is short, strongest last if you have the room and want it remembered.
- **It also works for structure.** Three sections in a talk, three bullets on a slide, three reasons in an argument.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Take a topic you could talk about for ten minutes. Reduce it to three points, each expressible in one sentence.
2. Say it aloud: “There are three things worth knowing about this. First...” Time it; aim for ninety seconds.
3. Do it again with a second topic, cold, without writing anything.
4. Rewrite a message you need to send today into exactly three points.
5. Use “three things” out loud in a real conversation today, and deliver exactly three.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Three things and then I will stop: cost, timing, and who owns it afterwards.”

“The decision comes down to three questions. Can we afford it, can we staff it, and can we support it in a year?”

WATCH OUT

Do not announce three and deliver six. It destroys trust in everything you say about time and structure. If you find a fourth point, either fold it into one of the three or leave it out.

JOURNAL

What are the three points of the most important thing I need to say this week?

DAY 44

DAY 44 OF 100

Plain Language Over Jargon

Focus: Say it the way you would explain it to a smart friend outside your field.

Jargon is efficient among specialists and a wall to everyone else. Most people use it defensively — it signals membership and hides uncertainty — but the cost is that decision-makers nod along without understanding, and then decide on something else. Plain language is not dumbing down; it is the harder skill, because it requires you to actually understand the thing.

LEARN

- **Test with a real person.** If you cannot explain it to an intelligent person outside your field, you do not yet understand it well enough.
- **Swap abstractions for actions.** “We will operationalise a framework for stakeholder alignment” means “we will agree with the three teams who is doing what.”
- **Keep only the jargon that earns its place.** Technical terms that are genuinely precise, used with people who know them, are fine. Say the plain version once first.
- **Kill the zombie nouns.** *Utilisation, implementation, facilitation.* Turn them back into verbs: use, do, help.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. List ten words and phrases you use at work that an outsider would not understand. Write a plain-English version of each.
2. Take a paragraph of your own writing and rewrite it with no jargon and no abstract nouns. Read both aloud.
3. Explain your current main project in five sentences to someone with no knowledge of your field. Notice exactly where they lose the thread.
4. Find the three zombie nouns you use most and convert them to verbs.
5. Use one plain-language explanation in a real meeting today instead of the usual shorthand.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Instead of “We need to leverage cross-functional synergies”: “The two teams need to work on this together.”

Instead of “There is a capacity constraint impacting delivery velocity”: “We do not have enough people, so it is going slower.”

WATCH OUT

Over-simplifying with specialists wastes their time and can read as patronising. Calibrate to the audience: plain language with mixed or senior groups, precise technical terms with your own discipline.

JOURNAL

Which piece of my own jargon am I using to hide uncertainty?

DAY 45

DAY 45 OF 100

Cut the Sentence in Half

Focus: Say the same thing in half the words.

Long sentences are hard to follow when spoken, because the listener has to hold the beginning in memory until the end arrives. Shortening them is mechanical: split at the conjunctions, delete the qualifiers, drop the throat-clearing. The result sounds more confident, not more abrupt, because certainty needs fewer words.

LEARN

- **One idea per sentence.** If you use *and* twice, you have three sentences.
- **Delete the openers.** *I just wanted to say, what I think is, the thing is that, in terms of.* All of these are throat-clearing.
- **Prefer the short word.** Use *rather* than *utilise*, *help* rather than *facilitate*, *now* rather than *at this point in time*.
- **Read aloud to find the problems.** Any sentence you cannot say on one comfortable breath is too long for speech.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Take five sentences from something you wrote recently. Rewrite each in half the words. Keep the meaning intact.
2. Read the original and the edit aloud, back to back. The edit will sound more certain.
3. Write your five longest habitual openers on a card and cross them out.
4. Take one paragraph and rewrite it with no sentence longer than fifteen words.
5. For one hour today, speak in short sentences on purpose. Full stops instead of *and*.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Before: "I was just wondering whether it might be possible for us to potentially look at moving the meeting, if that is not too inconvenient?"

After: "Can we move the meeting to Thursday?"

WATCH OUT

Very short sentences everywhere become choppy and can read as curt or robotic. Vary the length; the point is to remove the sprawling forty-word sentences, not to write telegrams.

JOURNAL

What is my most common throat-clearing phrase? How many words did I cut today?

DAY 46

DAY 46 OF 100

Signposting: Verbal Road Signs

Focus: Tell people where you are and where you are going.

Listeners cannot see your structure, scan ahead or re-read. They rely entirely on you to tell them how many parts there are, which part you are in, and when something important is coming. Signposting takes about eight extra words per section and dramatically increases how much people retain — especially on video calls, where attention leaks constantly.

LEARN

- **Open with a map.** “Three parts: what happened, what it cost, what I recommend.”
- **Mark the transitions.** “That is the problem. Now the options.” Transitions are where listeners get lost.
- **Flag importance explicitly.** “This next part is the one that matters.” It sounds obvious and it works.
- **Close the loop.** “So, back to the three parts: here is where we landed.”

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Write the signposting for something you need to explain this week: the opening map, two transitions and the closing loop.
2. Say a three-minute explanation aloud using them. Record it.
3. Listen back specifically for whether a stranger would know where they were at any moment.
4. Practise the four phrases until they are automatic: “Three parts...”, “That is X, now Y...”, “This is the important one...”, “So to close the loop...”
5. Use at least two signposts in a real meeting today.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “I will cover the problem, then two options, then what I need from you. Problem first.”

| “That is the background. The decision point is next, and it is the only part you need to remember.”

WATCH OUT

Heavy signposting in a two-minute conversation is bureaucratic. Scale it to length: one map for anything over three minutes, transitions for anything with sections, nothing for a quick exchange.

JOURNAL

Where did people last lose the thread of my explanation? Which signpost was missing?

DAY 47

DAY 47 OF 100

Concrete Beats Abstract

Focus: Replace general claims with numbers, names and examples.

Abstract statements are forgettable and unfalsifiable. “Customer satisfaction has improved” produces no picture and no belief. “Complaints dropped from forty a week to twelve” produces both. Concrete language is more persuasive, easier to remember and harder to argue with — and it forces you to check whether your claim is actually true.

LEARN

- **Numbers with a comparison.** A number alone means little; “twelve, down from forty” means something.
- **Names and places make it real.** “A customer in Leeds rang three times about the same fault” beats “there have been repeat contacts.”
- **One example, chosen well.** A single vivid case is remembered far longer than a summary of a hundred.
- **Make it visual and physical.** Comparisons to things people can picture do more work than percentages.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write down five abstract claims you regularly make about your work. Replace each with a number, a name or a specific example.
2. For each number, add the comparison that makes it meaningful.
3. Find one concrete example story from your work that you can tell in three sentences. Learn it.
4. Rewrite one paragraph of a document to remove every unsupported general claim.
5. Use one concrete example in a real conversation today instead of a general statement.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Instead of “we have a lot of technical debt”: “any change to the billing page takes three days because six files have to be edited by hand.”

Instead of “the training was well received”: “eighteen of twenty people said they would recommend it; the two who did not both wanted it shorter.”

WATCH OUT

Do not invent precision. A confident number that turns out to be wrong costs you more credibility than an honest estimate. “Roughly forty, I will confirm” is both concrete and safe.

JOURNAL

Which vague claim of mine could I make concrete with one number?

DAY 48

DAY 48 OF 100

Analogy and Metaphor

Focus: Explain the unfamiliar with something already familiar.

An analogy is the fastest way to move an idea from your head into someone else's, because it borrows a structure they already have. It is how good teachers, doctors and engineers explain complexity to non-specialists. One well-chosen comparison can save five minutes of explanation and be repeated accurately by the listener afterwards.

LEARN

- **Borrow from everyday life.** Traffic, plumbing, cooking, queues, houses, weather. Universal, physical and instantly visualised.
- **Map one relationship, not everything.** Say which part of the analogy holds: “it is like a queue — the more people you let in at once, the slower everyone moves.”
- **Name the limits.** “The analogy breaks down when...” prevents the listener from over-extending it and drawing wrong conclusions.
- **Test it on someone.** A bad analogy is worse than none, because it installs a wrong model that is hard to remove later.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Pick the most technical part of your work. Write three different analogies for it from everyday life.
2. Test each on someone who does not know the subject. Keep the one that produced the fewest wrong follow-up questions.
3. Add the limit sentence: where does your analogy stop being true?
4. Practise it aloud in under thirty seconds.
5. Use it once for real this week and note whether anyone repeated it back to you. That is the sign of a good one.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Technical debt is like a credit card. Borrowing speed now is fine; the problem is the interest, which you pay in every future change.”

“Think of the cache as a kitchen counter: fast to reach, but small, so you only keep out what you are using today.”

WATCH OUT

Avoid war, sport and mechanical analogies with audiences who may not share the reference or may find it alienating. If half the room has to decode the metaphor, it has cost you more than it earned.

JOURNAL

Which analogy for my work has landed best in the past? Why did it work?

DAY 49

DAY 49 OF 100

STAR: Tell It as a Story

Focus: Situation, Task, Action, Result — in ninety seconds.

“Tell me about a time when...” appears in interviews, performance reviews, sales conversations and introductions. Unstructured answers wander through context and never reach a result. STAR fixes it by forcing the parts into a fixed order and a fixed length — with the result, the part people actually want, guaranteed to arrive.

LEARN

- **Situation (15 sec).** Just enough context. Where, when, what was at stake.
- **Task (10 sec).** Your specific responsibility. Not the team's — yours.
- **Action (40 sec).** What *you* did, in steps, using *I* rather than *we*. This is the bulk and where interviewers look.
- **Result (20 sec).** The outcome, with a number where possible, plus one line on what you learned.

PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Choose three real experiences: one where you solved a problem, one where you handled a conflict, one where you failed and recovered.
2. Write each in the STAR structure, keeping the whole thing under two hundred words.
3. Say each aloud and time it. Cut until each is under ninety seconds.
4. Check the Action section: count how many times you said *we*. Change most of them to *I* where it is honest.
5. Tell one of them to somebody today and ask what they remember afterwards.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Last spring our biggest client threatened to leave after a billing error. [S] I was asked to own the recovery. [T] I called them the same day, brought the finance lead onto the call, sent a written timeline within twenty-four hours and checked in weekly for a month. [A] They renewed, and we cut billing errors by about eighty percent by adding one approval step. [R]”

WATCH OUT

The classic failure is spending sixty seconds on Situation and ten on Result. Interviewers are listening for Action and Result. If you run short on time, cut the context, never the outcome.

JOURNAL

Which of my three stories is weakest? What is missing — the action detail or the result?

DAY 50

DAY 50 OF 100

The Thirty-Second Version

Focus: Compress anything you are working on into thirty seconds.

You will be asked “what are you working on?” in lifts, corridors, interviews and social events, usually by someone with limited time and no context. Having a prepared, genuinely interesting thirty-second answer is disproportionately valuable, and having to build one forces you to work out what the point of your work actually is.

LEARN

- **Four beats:** who it is for, what problem it solves, what you are doing about it, where it is now.
- **Lead with the problem, not the method.** People connect with problems; methods only interest specialists.
- **End with a hook, not a full stop.** Leave one open thread so the other person can ask a question if they want to.
- **Have two versions.** One for people in your field, one for everyone else.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write the four beats for your current main project. One sentence each.
2. Say it aloud and time it. Trim to thirty seconds. Then write the non-specialist version.
3. Test both on two different people and note where their attention drops or their eyebrows move.
4. Add a hook: an open question, a surprising number, or the part that is still unsolved.
5. Use it for real today when someone asks what you are working on, then note which version you needed.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“We support about nine hundred small shops that lose a full day a week to stock counting. I am building the tool that does it from till data instead. First three shops start next month — the hard part is the ones with no reliable internet.”

WATCH OUT

A polished thirty-second pitch delivered to a casual question can sound like a sales script. Keep it conversational, and cut it short the moment they show more interest in one part — the goal is a conversation, not a recital.

JOURNAL

What is the hook in my thirty-second version? Did anyone ask a follow-up question?

CHECKPOINT

Part Five Review

You now have a full clarity toolkit: headline first, PREP, the rule of three, plain language, ruthless sentence cutting, signposting, concrete detail, analogy, STAR stories and a thirty-second version of your work. These are the structures that make you easy to work with and easy to promote.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I lead with the conclusion by default.
- ☐ I can answer any question in PREP without preparation.
- ☐ I group points in threes and deliver exactly three.
- ☐ I can explain my work with no jargon at all.
- ☐ I catch and cut my throat-clearing openers.
- ☐ I signpost anything longer than three minutes.
- ☐ I use numbers with comparisons rather than vague claims.
- ☐ I have one tested analogy for the technical part of my work.
- ☐ I have three STAR stories under ninety seconds each.
- ☐ I have a thirty-second version of my current project.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Record yourself doing three things back to back: a headline-first update on a real project (30 sec), a PREP answer to a real question (60 sec), and one STAR story (90 sec). Listen back with one question in mind: could a stranger repeat my main point afterwards? If not, the structure was not tight enough.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Leading with the point

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Structure under pressure

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Plain language

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Concreteness

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Story-telling

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If you still ramble under pressure, the cause is almost always that you are choosing the content and the structure at the same time. Buy the time to separate them: “Give me a second to put that in order.” Two seconds of silence and a chosen structure beats thirty seconds of thinking aloud.

PART SIX

Everyday Conversation and Connection

DAYS 51-60

Small talk has a bad reputation among people who find it difficult, and it is genuinely important: it is the mechanism by which strangers become people you can ask for things. The skills are mundane and learnable — how to open, how to keep it going without interrogating, how to remember a name, how to leave gracefully, and how to follow up so the connection is worth something later. None of it requires being extroverted.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Start a conversation with a stranger without a rehearsed line.
- Keep a conversation going for five minutes without it feeling like work.
- Remember names reliably, and recover gracefully when you forget.
- Leave a conversation without awkwardness or an invented excuse.
- Follow up after meeting someone so the connection actually persists.

DAY 51

DAY 51 OF 100

Open a Conversation With Anyone

Focus: Use the situation in front of you as the opener.

People who find small talk hard usually believe they need a clever line. They do not. Almost all natural conversations start with a shared, obvious observation about the situation — the queue, the weather, the venue, the talk everyone just watched. The content of the opener is nearly irrelevant; what matters is that it is easy to answer.

LEARN

- **Observation plus question is the universal formula.** “Longer queue than I expected — have you been to one of these before?”
- **Make it easy to answer.** A good opener can be answered with one sentence by anyone present. Clever openers create pressure.
- **Your face opens before your mouth.** Eyebrow raise, eye contact, small smile, then speak. Without that, even a good opener lands strangely.
- **Volunteer first when asking anything personal.** “I came for the second talk, mostly. What about you?” Giving first makes the question feel like sharing.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write five openers based on situations you will be in this week: a queue, a lift, a waiting room, a meeting before it starts, a shop.
2. Use three of them today with strangers you will never see again. Baristas, shop assistants, people waiting.
3. Note what happened. Count the ones that led to more than one exchange; even one in three is normal and fine.
4. Practise the face sequence first: eyebrows, eye contact, smile, then the opener.
5. Do one opener where you volunteer something about yourself before asking anything.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “That looks better than what I ordered. Worth getting next time?”

| “I have never been to one of these before — do you know if it is worth staying for the panel?”

WATCH OUT

Some people do not want to talk, and that is not a verdict on you. Read the signals: headphones, a book, closed posture, minimal answers. Offer once, accept the answer gracefully, and move on.

JOURNAL

How many openers did I try? Which one felt easiest, and why?

DAY 52

DAY 52 OF 100

FORD: Never Run Out of Topics

Focus: Family, Occupation, Recreation, Dreams.

The panic in small talk is usually about running out of things to say. FORD removes that fear by giving you four inexhaustible territories that work with almost anyone, in almost any culture, at almost any level of acquaintance. You do not need to remember anything else; four words cover most of human small talk.

LEARN

- **Family.** Anyone they live with, care for or grew up around. Handle gently and follow their lead; not everyone wants to discuss it.
- **Occupation.** What they do, how they got into it, what the good and bad parts are. “How did you get into that?” is the best single question in this territory.
- **Recreation.** What they do outside work. Usually the richest and safest ground, because people are pleased to be asked.
- **Dreams.** What they want next: a trip, a move, a plan, a project. Surprisingly easy and instantly more interesting than the other three.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write two questions for each FORD category, in your own words. Eight questions total.
2. In two conversations today, deliberately move across at least three of the four territories.
3. Practise the transition: pick up something they said, then move category. “You mentioned you moved here for the job — what do you do when you are not working?”
4. Notice which category you avoid. Most people avoid one, usually for good reasons; know which it is.
5. Do a full five-minute conversation with a stranger or acquaintance using only FORD questions and follow-ups.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “How did you end up doing that?”

| “What are you hoping to do next year that you have not managed yet?”

WATCH OUT

FORD is a fallback, not a script. Working through the categories in order turns a conversation into a questionnaire. Use it when you are stuck, not as the plan.

JOURNAL

Which FORD category do I avoid? Which one gets the best responses from others?

DAY 53

DAY 53 OF 100

Remember and Use Names

Focus: Get the name, keep the name, use the name.

Using someone's name correctly is one of the strongest and cheapest signals of respect available, and forgetting it is one of the most quietly damaging. Most people who "are bad with names" never actually encoded the name in the first place, because they were busy managing their own nerves during the introduction.

LEARN

- **Hear it properly.** If you did not catch it, ask immediately. Asking twice in the first ten seconds is fine; asking in ten minutes is awkward.
- **Say it back at once.** "Good to meet you, Ravi." Saying it aloud is what moves it from sound to memory.
- **Attach it to something.** A visual detail, a shared feature, someone else with the name, or the place you met. Any hook beats none.
- **Use it twice more.** Once in the middle of the conversation, once when you leave. Three uses and it usually stays.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Practise the full sequence with three people today: hear it, repeat it back immediately, attach a hook, use it again when parting.
2. If you miss a name, use the recovery line straight away: "Sorry, I did not catch your name."
3. Practise the harder recovery for later: "I have completely lost your name and I would rather ask than guess." Say it out loud a few times so it is available when needed.
4. For unfamiliar names, ask how to pronounce it and repeat until you have it. This is a courtesy, not an imposition.
5. At the end of the day, list every name you learned. Anything you cannot recall shows where the sequence broke.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| "Sorry — say it again for me? I want to get it right."

| "That was really useful, Miriam. I will send you that link this afternoon."

WATCH OUT

Do not over-use names. Repeating someone's name in every sentence is a known sales tactic and it reads as insincere or vaguely threatening. Three times in a conversation is plenty.

JOURNAL

How many new names did I retain today? Where did the sequence break down?

DAY 54

DAY 54 OF 100

Make Other People Feel Interesting

Focus: Give sincere attention rather than seeking it.

The people described as brilliant conversationalists usually talk less than average. What they do is make the other person feel that what they said was worth hearing: they follow up, they remember details, they react. This is not a manipulation technique; it is simply generous attention, and it is rarer than it should be.

LEARN

- **React before you respond.** A genuine “oh, really?” or a laugh is worth more than a well-constructed reply.
- **Ask about the part they lit up on.** People signal what they care about with energy. Follow the energy, not the topic.
- **Remember and reference.** Bringing up something they told you last time is the strongest connection signal in this book.
- **Resist the topper.** When they share something, your matching story usually shifts the spotlight. Delay it by one question, or leave it out.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. In three conversations, notice the exact moment their energy rises. Ask a follow-up question about that specific thing.
2. Practise the delayed topper: when you want to tell your own related story, ask one more question first.
3. Reference something from a previous conversation with two different people today.
4. Keep a note of one detail per person you talk to this week. A file, a note on your phone — whatever you will actually use.
5. At the end of a conversation, silently estimate what share of the talking you did. Aim for well under half.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “You mentioned last time you were learning to sail — how is that going?”

| “Wait, go back — you built the whole thing yourself?”

WATCH OUT

This becomes a problem if you never share anything. One-way attention makes people feel interviewed and slightly uneasy, because they know nothing about you. Tomorrow's day is the balance.

JOURNAL

Whose energy did I follow today? What percentage of the talking was mine?

DAY 55

DAY 55 OF 100

Share Something of Your Own

Focus: Offer real information about yourself at a matched depth.

Connection requires reciprocity. If you only ask questions, people feel examined rather than met, and the relationship stays one-directional. The skill is calibration: sharing something real, at roughly the depth they offered, without either hiding behind facts or over-sharing and creating discomfort.

LEARN

- **Match the depth.** They mention a stressful week; you mention yours. They mention a divorce; you do not respond with the weather, but you also do not escalate.
- **Specific beats general.** “I spent Sunday failing to fix a bike” is warm and human. “It was fine, quiet weekend” closes the door.
- **Small vulnerability builds trust; large vulnerability transfers weight.** Admitting a small struggle invites closeness. Unloading a crisis onto a new acquaintance makes them responsible for you.
- **Opinions count as self-disclosure.** A genuine, mild opinion is more revealing and more interesting than any list of facts.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write three genuinely true, specific things about your week that you would be comfortable telling an acquaintance.
2. Use one of them today, unprompted, in a conversation where you would normally have said “fine, busy.”
3. Practise matching depth: in one conversation, share at roughly the level they did, and note how the conversation changed.
4. Offer one mild opinion about something harmless instead of a neutral non-answer.
5. Note anyone who reciprocated with something more personal. That is the mechanism working.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Instead of “fine, thanks”: “Honestly, a bit of a mess — I have been trying to hire someone for two months and keep losing candidates at the final stage.”

“I am the wrong person to ask about that. I gave up on running twice this year already.”

WATCH OUT

Over-sharing early is the main risk, especially with people who have power over you. Test with something small first and watch whether they reciprocate. If they do not, stay at that level.

JOURNAL

What did I share today that I would normally have kept behind a polite non-answer?

DAY 56

DAY 56 OF 100

Read the Room and Match the Energy

Focus: Adjust your register to the situation before you speak.

Most social misfires are not about content; they are about register. A joke in a subdued room, a long story in a hurried corridor, high energy in a room full of tired people — all read as being out of step. Spending the first thirty seconds reading a room before contributing prevents nearly all of it.

LEARN

- **Read three things: energy, formality and speed.** Are people animated or flat? Is the language careful or loose? Is everyone rushing?
- **Enter at their level, then adjust.** Arriving at your own energy level regardless of the room is what makes people feel steamrollered.
- **Watch the highest-status person's register.** Groups tend to calibrate to it, whether or not they realise.
- **Notice the topic temperature.** If people are being careful about a subject, there is a reason. Ask privately rather than publicly.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Before joining three groups or meetings today, spend twenty seconds reading energy, formality and speed. Write your assessment down afterwards.
2. Enter one at the room's level rather than your own, and note the difference in how you were received.
3. In one meeting, identify the topic everyone is treading carefully around. Do not raise it publicly; ask one person afterwards.
4. Practise the register check: "Is now a good time, or shall I catch you later?"
5. Deliberately mismatch once, in a safe setting, and observe the reaction. It is instructive.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| "You all look like you have had a day. Do you want the update now or tomorrow morning?"

| "I have got something light and something serious. Which do you want first?"

WATCH OUT

Reading the room should not become permanent self-suppression. If you always shrink to the room's mood, you never bring anything. Read, adjust, then contribute — the adjustment is to the delivery, not to whether you speak.

JOURNAL

Where was I out of step with a room recently? Energy, formality or speed?

DAY 57

DAY 57 OF 100

Exit a Conversation Gracefully

Focus: Leave clearly, warmly and without an invented excuse.

Fear of not being able to leave is one of the main reasons people avoid starting conversations at events. A reliable exit makes the whole thing lower risk. A good exit has three parts and takes eight seconds, and it leaves the other person feeling well treated rather than dropped.

LEARN

- **Signal, value, leave.** Signal the ending, say what was worth having, then state what you are doing next.
- **Do not invent errands.** “I am going to get a drink and say hello to a few more people” is honest and entirely acceptable at an event.
- **Add a bridge if you want to continue.** “Can I message you about that?” converts a conversation into a contact.
- **Introduce them onward when you can.** Handing someone to another person is the most generous exit there is.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Write your standard exit line and memorise it. One for events, one for the office, one for phone calls.
2. Use it twice today. Practise it in low-stakes conversations first.
3. Practise the bridge version: exit plus a specific next step.
4. Try the introduction exit once: bring a third person in and hand over the conversation.
5. Note whether any exit felt abrupt. Usually the missing part is the *value* sentence.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I am glad we talked — the point about pricing is going to stay with me. I am going to go and find the coffee. Can I message you about it next week?”

“I need to let you go, but before I do: who else here should I be talking to?”

WATCH OUT

Fading out without an exit — shortening answers, glancing away, drifting off — is worse than a slightly clumsy explicit exit. People remember being dropped.

JOURNAL

Which exit felt most natural? Where do I usually get stuck instead of leaving?

DAY 58

DAY 58 OF 100

Light Humour Without Risk

Focus: Use warmth-building humour, not high-risk jokes.

Humour is the strongest rapport accelerator available and the easiest way to damage a relationship in one sentence. The distinction is what the humour is aimed at. Shared observations and gentle self-deprecation build connection at almost no risk; humour aimed at people, groups or sensitivities can end a working relationship instantly.

LEARN

- **Aim at the situation.** Traffic, weather, technology, queues, the absurdity of the process. Shared experience, no target.
- **Mild self-deprecation only.** “I have already broken the coffee machine once today.” Heavy self-criticism makes people uncomfortable and can read as fishing for reassurance.
- **Never punch down.** Humour about anyone with less power than you, or about protected characteristics, is not a risk to be managed. It is simply off the table.
- **Laughing at others' jokes is most of it.** Being someone who finds things funny counts more than being someone who says funny things.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Write three observations about shared frustrations in your environment that could be said lightly.
2. Use one today. Note whether it landed; if it did not, move on without repairing it at length.
3. Practise one line of mild self-deprecation about something genuinely low-stakes.
4. Spend one day noticing when others make jokes and responding warmly rather than staying neutral.
5. Identify one thing you joke about that you should stop. Everyone has one.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“This meeting has now outlived two of my calendar invitations.”

“I have read this document three times and I am still not sure it is in English.”

WATCH OUT

Sarcasm about people, and jokes at a colleague's expense, are the two failure modes that cause real damage — particularly in writing, where tone is invisible and the message can be forwarded. When in doubt, leave it out.

JOURNAL

What kind of humour do I default to? Is any of it aimed at people rather than situations?

DAY 59

DAY 59 OF 100

Work a Room Without Dread

Focus: Have a plan that makes events survivable and useful.

Networking events are unpleasant mostly because people arrive without a plan and try to be generally sociable for two hours. With a small structure — a target number of conversations, a few openers, an exit line and permission to leave early — the same event becomes finite and manageable, even for introverts.

LEARN

- **Set a small quota.** Three real conversations, then you may leave. Three is achievable and worth more than twenty exchanges of business cards.
- **Arrive early.** Early rooms are quieter, groups are smaller and joining is far easier than breaking into established circles.
- **Join open groups of three or more.** Two people may be mid-conversation; three or more is usually open. Stand at the edge, listen for a moment, then contribute.
- **Talk to the person alone.** They are the most grateful person in the room and the easiest to approach.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write your event plan for the next one you attend: quota, three openers, exit line, permission to leave at a set time.
2. Practise the joining move: “Mind if I join you? I do not know anybody here yet.” It works almost universally.
3. Practise the two questions you will ask everyone, so you do not need to improvise: “What brought you here?” and “What are you working on at the moment?”
4. If you have no event coming up, run the plan at any group setting: a class, a team lunch, a queue at a conference.
5. Afterwards, write who you met and one detail about each. This is the step nearly everyone skips.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Mind if I join you? I do not know anyone here yet.”

| “What brought you along to this one?”

WATCH OUT

Do not treat rooms as transaction opportunities. People detect being worked, and it is the fastest way to be avoided. Aim for three conversations you enjoyed, not thirty contacts.

JOURNAL

How did having a quota and an exit change how the event felt?

DAY 60

DAY 60 OF 100

Follow Up So It Leads Somewhere

Focus: Convert conversations into relationships with one message.

Almost nobody follows up, which is precisely why following up works. A short message within forty-eight hours, referencing something specific from the conversation, is enough to make someone remember you months later. Without it, ninety percent of the effort you spent meeting people evaporates within a week.

LEARN

- **Within forty-eight hours.** After that you need to explain who you are, which is a much harder message to write.
- **Reference something specific.** Not “great to meet you” but “your point about the tender process stuck with me.” Specificity proves you were present.
- **Give before you ask.** Send the article, the introduction, the answer to their question. A first message that asks for something is a cold pitch.
- **Then keep a light rhythm.** Two or three genuine touches a year, tied to something real, keeps a contact warm without effort or awkwardness.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. List everyone you have met in the last month and not followed up with.
2. Send three follow-up messages today, each four sentences or fewer: where you met, the specific thing you remember, something useful you can give, and an open door.
3. Set up a simple system: a note per person with one detail and the date you last spoke.
4. Put a recurring reminder in your calendar to review that list once a month.
5. Write the template you will reuse, so the next follow-up takes two minutes rather than twenty.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Hi Dana — we talked at the logistics meetup about warehouse staffing. You mentioned the seasonal peak problem; the article below is the one I was trying to remember. No need to reply — just thought it might be useful.”

WATCH OUT

Automated or copy-pasted follow-ups are worse than silence: they are obvious, and they tell the recipient they were part of a batch. Four genuine sentences beat a hundred generic ones.

JOURNAL

Who have I lost touch with who I should not have? What is the one message that reopens it?

CHECKPOINT

Part Six Review

You can now open a conversation with a stranger, keep it going with FORD and follow-ups, remember names, give and receive attention in balance, read a room, leave cleanly, use humour safely, survive an event with a plan, and follow up so that any of it matters a month later.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I have started conversations with at least five strangers this part.
- ☐ I can move between three FORD territories without effort.
- ☐ I use the hear-repeat-hook-use sequence for names.
- ☐ I follow the other person's energy rather than my planned topic.
- ☐ I share something real rather than defaulting to "fine, busy."
- ☐ I read energy, formality and speed before entering a group.
- ☐ I have an exit line I can use without inventing an excuse.
- ☐ My humour is aimed at situations, not people.
- ☐ I have an event plan with a quota and a leave time.
- ☐ I have sent three specific follow-up messages.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Have one genuinely new conversation of at least five minutes with someone you do not know, in person. Use an opener based on the situation, learn and use their name, go three questions deep, share something real of your own, and exit with the three-part close. Follow up within forty-eight hours if it makes sense.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Starting conversations

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Keeping them going

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Names and details

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Balance of asking and sharing

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Exits and follow-up

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If this part was the hardest so far, that is extremely common and not a character flaw. Keep the volume low and the frequency high: two thirty-second exchanges with strangers a day, every day, for a month. Frequency, not duration, is what removes the dread.

PART SEVEN

Written and Digital Communication

DAYS 61-70

Most of your communication is now written, asynchronous and permanent. It is also where tone is invisible, misreadings are common and your reputation is built one message at a time.

Written skill is largely mechanical: put the point first, make the ask explicit, format for people who skim, and add the warmth that text strips out. This part covers email, chat, updates, notes, documents and your public profile.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Write emails that get read, understood and answered the first time.
- Make requests so easy to action that people say yes quickly.
- Control tone in text so your messages are not misread as cold or angry.
- Write updates, recaps and documents that busy people can skim accurately.
- Describe yourself in writing without cliché or false modesty.

DAY 61

DAY 61 OF 100

Write the Way You Speak, Only Tighter

Focus: Remove the artificial formality from your writing.

Many people switch into a stiff, official register the moment they start typing: passive voice, long words, borrowed phrases like *please be advised*. It reads as cold and evasive, and it takes longer to write. The best professional writing sounds like a clear person talking — with the redundancy of speech removed.

LEARN

- **Say it out loud first, then type that.** If you would never say a sentence aloud, do not write it.
- **Prefer the active voice.** “We missed the deadline” rather than “the deadline was not met.” Passive voice hides who did what, which is sometimes the point — but rarely a good one.
- **Use contractions and normal words.** *Do not* rather than *shall not*, *use* rather than *utilise*, *about* rather than *approximately*.
- **Cut the borrowed phrases.** *Please be advised*, *as per my last email*, *kindly revert*, *at your earliest convenience*. All of them can be deleted or replaced with plain words.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Take an email you sent recently and read it aloud. Mark every sentence you would not say to the person's face.
2. Rewrite it as you would say it, then trim the repetition speech naturally contains.
3. Make a list of the five stock phrases you overuse, and write the plain replacement for each.
4. Find every passive construction in one document you wrote and rewrite them in the active voice. Note the ones where the passive was hiding an owner.
5. Write today's most important message this way, then read it aloud before sending.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Instead of “Please be advised that the aforementioned deliverable has been delayed”: “The report will be late. I will send it Thursday.”

Instead of “As per my previous email...”: “Chasing this one — I know you have had a busy week.”

WATCH OUT

Informal is not the same as sloppy. Typos, missing capitals and unstructured walls of text read as careless in professional writing. Sound like a person; edit like an editor.

JOURNAL

Which stock phrase do I use most? What would I actually say out loud instead?

DAY 62

DAY 62 OF 100

Email That Gets Read and Answered

Focus: Point, ask, deadline, in that order.

The average professional gets far more email than they can read properly, so they triage in seconds. An email that buries its purpose in paragraph three gets postponed, and postponed email is functionally unsent. A well-structured email is actionable in the first ten seconds and takes less time to write than a rambling one.

LEARN

- **First line carries the point.** State the purpose and what you need. No warm-up paragraph.
- **One email, one topic.** Two requests in one email reliably produces one answer. Send two emails.
- **Make the ask explicit and bounded.** Who does what, by when. “Can you confirm by Thursday?” not “let me know your thoughts.”
- **Format for skimming.** Short paragraphs, bold the ask, bullets for options. If it is over two hundred words, add a one-line summary at the top.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Take your last five sent emails. Score each: could the recipient tell what you wanted in ten seconds?
2. Rewrite the worst one using the structure: point, context, ask, deadline.
3. Write your next real email in that structure. Bold the ask.
4. Practise the summary line for a long email: “Short version: I need approval on the budget by Friday. Detail below.”
5. Split any email in your drafts that contains more than one request.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I need one decision from you: do we go with option A or B? Both are costed below. A five-word reply is fine — I need it by Thursday to hold the supplier price.”

WATCH OUT

Do not strip out all the human content in the name of efficiency. A single line of acknowledgement — “Hope the launch went well” — costs three seconds and prevents your message reading as a demand from a machine.

JOURNAL

How many of my last five emails made the ask obvious in the first line?

DAY 63

DAY 63 OF 100

Subject Lines and First Lines

Focus: Write the two lines that decide whether anything else is read.

The subject line determines whether your email is opened now, later or never; the first line determines whether it is read or filed. Together they are perhaps fifteen words that carry more weight than the rest of the message. Most people write them last and carelessly, which is why so much good work goes unread.

LEARN

- **Subject lines should be specific and contain the verb.** “Approval needed: Q3 budget by Fri” beats “Budget”.
- **Front-load the type.** *Action needed, FYI only, Decision, Question.* It lets people triage correctly, which they will appreciate.
- **Include the deadline in the subject when there is one.** It is the single most useful piece of metadata you can add.
- **The first line should never be a greeting plus filler.** “Hi Sam — I need one decision from you” is a first line. “Hope you are well. I am writing to follow up regarding...” is not.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Look at the last twenty subject lines you sent. Rewrite five of them to be specific and actionable.
2. Write five subject lines using the pattern: [type]: [thing] by [date].
3. Rewrite the first line of three recent emails so the purpose arrives immediately.
4. Check your own inbox: which subject lines made you open immediately, and why?
5. Apply both to every email you send today.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “Decision needed: supplier choice, by Thu 14th”

| “FYI only — no action: notes from the client call”

WATCH OUT

Do not manufacture urgency. Marking things urgent when they are not is the fastest way to have your emails ignored permanently, and colleagues remember it for years.

JOURNAL

Which of my subject lines from this week would I have opened last?

DAY 64

DAY 64 OF 100

Tone in Text: Avoiding Misreads

Focus: Add back the warmth that writing strips out.

Text carries no voice, face or timing, so readers supply their own — and under stress they supply a negative one. A message you wrote in four seconds while busy can read as annoyed, dismissive or cold. Since you cannot control their mood, you have to over-supply warmth and explicitness in writing, particularly when there is any tension.

LEARN

- **Brevity reads as coldness.** A one-word reply from someone senior is read as displeasure. Add three words of warmth or context.
- **Name your tone when it matters.** “Genuine question, not a criticism” prevents an hour of anxiety.
- **Assume good intent in what you receive.** Most cold messages are written by busy people, not angry ones. Ask before reacting.
- **Escalate the channel when tone matters.** If a thread has more than three rounds of clarification, or any emotion, pick up the phone. Text is the worst medium for repair.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Find three messages you sent that could be read as cold. Rewrite them with one line of warmth added.
2. Find one message you *received* that annoyed you. Reread it assuming the sender was busy and well-intentioned. Note the difference.
3. Practise naming tone: “Asking out of curiosity, not concern”; “This is a nudge, not a complaint.”
4. Identify one email thread that should become a call, and convert it today.
5. Write, then wait: draft one emotionally charged message and do not send it for an hour. Reread before sending.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Quick question and genuinely no rush — has the invoice gone out? Only asking because I am closing the month.”

“I am reading this thread as us disagreeing, and I might be wrong. Ten minutes on a call?”

WATCH OUT

Punctuation carries tone whether you intend it or not. A full stop after a single word (“Fine.”), all-caps, and an unexplained “ok” all read as displeasure to most readers. So does a very late-night send time.

JOURNAL

Which of my messages have been misread recently? What was missing from them?

DAY 65

DAY 65 OF 100

Chat and Instant Messaging

Focus: Use chat for speed without creating chaos.

Chat tools compress everything: less structure, more interruption, higher expectation of instant reply. Used well they are the fastest way to unblock work. Used badly they fragment attention across a team and make important decisions impossible to find later.

LEARN

- **One message, not seven.** Compose the whole thought, then send. Serial fragments notify people repeatedly and read as frantic.
- **Never send just “hi” and wait.** State your question in the first message. The greeting-and-wait pattern strands the other person.
- **Use threads and channels properly.** Public channel for anything others may need; thread to keep a topic together; direct message only for genuinely private matters.
- **Move decisions out of chat.** Anything that will matter next month belongs in a document, ticket or email, with chat as the discussion, not the record.

PRACTICE TODAY — 15 MINUTES

1. Review your last twenty chat messages. Count how many were fragments that should have been one message.
2. Practise the full-context single message: greeting, question, deadline, all in one send.
3. Set your own response expectations explicitly with one person today: “I check messages twice a day; if it is urgent, call me.”
4. Find one decision that lives only in a chat thread and write it down somewhere durable.
5. Turn off notifications for two hours and note what actually broke. Usually nothing.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Hi Nadia — quick one: can I use last month's figures in the board pack, or is there a revised set? Need to know by 4pm, no rush before then.”

“Summarising here so it is findable: we agreed option B, Ana owns it, review on the 12th.”

WATCH OUT

Instant availability is not a virtue. Replying within seconds all day trains everyone to expect it and destroys your ability to do anything requiring concentration. Set expectations early and hold them.

JOURNAL

What is my worst chat habit? What did I change today?

DAY 66

DAY 66 OF 100

Async Updates People Actually Read

Focus: Write a status update in a fixed, skimmable shape.

Status updates are read by people who want to know two things: is it on track, and do you need anything from me. Most updates answer neither, and instead list activity. A fixed structure makes yours readable in fifteen seconds, and it also builds a reputation for reliability that is worth more than the update itself.

LEARN

- **Lead with a status word.** *On track, at risk, blocked, done.* One word tells a manager whether to keep reading.
- **Then: progress, next, blockers, asks.** Four short sections, in that order. Blockers and asks are the sections people care about most and that get omitted most often.
- **Report outcomes, not activity.** “Payment flow live for ten percent of users” not “worked on payments.”
- **Raise risk early and plainly.** Nobody minds bad news early; everybody minds it late. Flagging at week two costs nothing; flagging at week six costs your credibility.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write this week's real update in the structure: status word, progress, next, blockers, asks. Cap it at 150 words.
2. Check every line: is it an outcome or an activity? Rewrite the activities.
3. Add one explicit ask, even a small one. Updates with no asks train people to skim them.
4. Ask one recipient whether it told them what they needed. Adjust.
5. Save it as your reusable template.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“At risk. Payments integration is live in test but the refund path fails for split payments. Next: fix the refund path (2 days), then re-test. Blocker: I need a test account from Finance. Ask: can someone chase that today? Slipping past Wednesday puts the launch date at risk.”

WATCH OUT

Do not use the status word dishonestly. Reporting green for weeks and then red without warning is the single fastest way to lose trust with a manager, and it is remembered long after the project is forgotten.

JOURNAL

Was my last update about outcomes or activity? Did it contain a real ask?

DAY 67

DAY 67 OF 100

Meeting Notes and Recaps

Focus: Send a five-line recap that becomes the record.

The person who writes the recap defines what happened. That is not a political trick; it is a service everyone benefits from, and it disproportionately increases your influence because you are the one who turns discussion into commitments. It takes five minutes and almost nobody does it.

LEARN

- **Send it within the day.** After twenty-four hours, memories have diverged and the recap becomes contested.
- **Three sections only:** decisions, actions with owners and dates, open questions.
- **Name people explicitly.** “Someone will look into it” guarantees nobody will. “Jon checks with Legal by Tuesday” works.
- **Invite correction with a deadline.** “Shout if I have got any of this wrong by tomorrow midday.” This converts silence into agreement.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Take notes in your next meeting using three headings: decisions, actions, open questions.
2. Send the recap within two hours. Keep it under 120 words.
3. Make sure every action has a name and a date. Chase the ambiguous ones during the meeting: “Who owns that, and by when?”
4. Add the correction line at the end.
5. Do this for every meeting for a week and note how it changes how people treat you in those meetings.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Decisions: we go with supplier B. Actions: Ana signs the contract by Fri 12th; I brief the team Monday. Open: who owns the training — not resolved. Corrections to me by tomorrow midday, otherwise I will assume this is right.”

WATCH OUT

Do not use the recap to record what you wish had been agreed. Any inaccuracy, especially a self-serving one, will be spotted and will cost you the credibility the habit was earning you.

JOURNAL

What happened when I sent the recap? Did anyone correct it?

DAY 68

DAY 68 OF 100

Requests: Make It Easy to Say Yes

Focus: Ask so clearly that the answer takes ten seconds.

Most requests fail because they make the other person do work: work out what is being asked, decide the scope, choose a time, find the information. Every unit of effort you remove increases the chance of a yes. A well-formed request is specific, bounded, easy to refuse and easy to accept.

LEARN

- **Be specific about the what, the size and the when.** “Twenty minutes on Thursday to review two pages” not “some help with the report.”
- **Say why it is them.** A one-line reason — their expertise, their involvement — makes a request feel considered rather than random.
- **Give an easy exit.** “If you are stretched, just say so and I will ask Marco.” Counter-intuitively this raises acceptance, because it removes the pressure.
- **Do the preparation for them.** Attach the document, propose two times, pre-fill the form. Every removed step matters.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write out three requests you need to make. For each, specify: what exactly, how long it will take, by when, and why this person.
2. Add an easy exit line to each.
3. Remove one step of work for the recipient in each: attach the file, propose the times, draft the text they would have to write.
4. Send two of them today.
5. Note the response times compared with your usual requests.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Can I borrow twenty minutes on Thursday or Friday? I want your read on two pages of the pricing section — you know the client better than anyone. Both slots are in your calendar as tentative; if you are stretched this week, say so and I will ask Marco instead.”

WATCH OUT

Over-apologising undermines a good request. “I am so sorry to bother you, I know you are incredibly busy, this is probably annoying...” makes the reader work through your discomfort before reaching the ask. One line of acknowledgement is enough.

JOURNAL

Which of my requests get ignored? What work am I leaving for the other person?

DAY 69

DAY 69 OF 100

Documents for People Who Skim

Focus: Structure long writing so it can be read at three depths.

Nobody reads a long document linearly. Executives read the summary, managers read the headings, specialists read the detail. If your document only works when read from start to finish, most readers will get the wrong idea or none at all. Writing at three depths is a formatting job, not a writing one.

LEARN

- **Summary at the top, always.** Five lines: the situation, the recommendation, the cost, the risk, what you need. Assume some readers will read nothing else.
- **Headings that state conclusions.** “Costs rise sharply after year two” is a heading. “Costs” is a label. Conclusion-headings let people skim the argument.
- **One idea per paragraph, first sentence carries it.** A reader should be able to read only first sentences and follow the whole document.
- **Put detail in appendices.** Protect the main line of argument; move the workings, data and edge cases to the back.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Take a document you have written. Write the five-line summary it is missing.
2. Rewrite every heading as a conclusion rather than a label.
3. Check each paragraph: does the first sentence carry the idea? Fix three that do not.
4. Move two sections of detail to an appendix and see whether the argument reads better.
5. Give it to someone with fifteen seconds and ask what they think it says. Their answer tells you whether the top-level layer works.

WATCH OUT

Do not let the summary and the body disagree. Documents revised many times often end with a summary describing an earlier version of the recommendation — an error that destroys confidence in everything else.

JOURNAL

Does my most important document work if someone only reads the headings?

DAY 70

DAY 70 OF 100

Your Profile, Bio and Introduction

Focus: Describe yourself in plain, specific, non-cliché language.

Your written self-description is read far more often than you think: profiles, signatures, speaker bios, applications, introductions to new teams. Most are built entirely from cliché — passionate, results-driven, strategic thinker — which communicates nothing. A specific, concrete description stands out immediately, precisely because it is so rare.

LEARN

- **Specific over impressive.** “I help hospital pharmacies cut dispensing errors” beats “experienced healthcare transformation professional.”
- **Ban the cliché list.** Passionate, driven, dynamic, synergy, thought leader, results-oriented, guru, ninja. All of them are noise.
- **Include a number and a proof point.** Numbers are believable and memorable; adjectives are neither.
- **Write three lengths.** One line for a signature or badge, three lines for a profile, a paragraph for a bio. You will need all three repeatedly.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write the one-line version: what you do, for whom, with what result. Under fifteen words.
2. Write the three-line version: what you do, one proof point with a number, one human detail that makes you a person.
3. Write the paragraph version for a speaker bio or an application.
4. Delete every cliché and adjective, then read it back. If it still says something, it is good.
5. Test the one-liner on someone: ask them to repeat it back. If they cannot, simplify it.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

One line: “I train call-centre teams to handle complaints without escalating them.”

Three lines: “I train call-centre teams to handle complaints without escalating them. Last year we cut escalations by a third across four sites. Before this I spent six years on the phones myself, which is where most of the material comes from.”

WATCH OUT

False modesty is as unhelpful as inflation. “I just do a bit of everything” wastes the reader's time and undersells work that is worth describing. State plainly what you do and what happened as a result.

JOURNAL

Does my current profile say anything a competitor could not also claim?

CHECKPOINT

Part Seven Review

Your writing now leads with the point, makes explicit asks, controls tone deliberately, uses chat without chaos, produces updates and recaps people rely on, structures documents for skimmers, and describes you in specific rather than cliché terms.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I read important messages aloud before sending them.
- ☐ My emails state the ask in the first line, with a deadline.
- ☐ My subject lines contain a type, a topic and a date.
- ☐ I add warmth deliberately, and name my tone when there is tension.
- ☐ I send complete thoughts in chat rather than fragments.
- ☐ My updates start with a status word and contain a real ask.
- ☐ I send a recap after important meetings, within the day.
- ☐ My requests are specific, bounded and easy to refuse.
- ☐ My documents have a five-line summary and conclusion-headings.
- ☐ My one-line self-description contains no clichés.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Take the longest email or document you have written in the last month. Rewrite it completely: point in the first line, conclusion-headings, one idea per paragraph, explicit ask with a deadline, half the original word count. Then send the rewritten version to someone and ask them to tell you what it wants from them.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Clarity of the ask

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Structure and skimmability

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Tone control

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Updates and recaps

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Self-description

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If your writing still feels stiff, the cause is nearly always editing while drafting. Separate them: write the whole thing badly and fast, then cut it by a third. The cutting pass is where all the quality comes from.

PART EIGHT

The Professional Arena

DAYS 71-80

Careers are shaped in meetings, updates, feedback conversations and interviews — not in the quality of the work alone. This part is about the specific communication moves that decide whether your work is seen, whether your objections are heard, and whether people trust you with more. It also covers the two skills most people never learn: how to say no, and how to receive criticism without defending.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Contribute in meetings early, briefly and usefully.
- Run a meeting that ends on time with clear decisions.
- Give feedback that changes behaviour without damaging the relationship.
- Say no, or say yes with conditions, without harming your standing.
- Answer interview questions with structure and specific evidence.

DAY 71

DAY 71 OF 100

Speak Up in Meetings

Focus: Contribute in the first ten minutes, briefly.

In meetings, silence is read as having nothing to add, whatever the reason for it. The longer you wait, the higher the bar becomes: after twenty minutes of silence you feel your contribution must be excellent to justify itself. Speaking early and briefly resets that entirely, and it is much easier than it sounds.

LEARN

- **Speak within the first ten minutes.** It can be small: a question, an agreement with a reason, a clarification. Once you have spoken, speaking again is easy.
- **Four low-risk entries.** Ask a clarifying question; build on someone's point; summarise where the discussion is; state a concern with a suggestion.
- **Say your headline, then stop.** Contributions over thirty seconds are usually interrupted anyway. Give the point and let the room pull the detail out of you.
- **Prepare two things beforehand.** One question and one point. Preparation, not confidence, is what makes people sound spontaneous.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Before your next three meetings, write one question and one point you could make. Keep them on your notes page.
2. In each meeting, speak within the first ten minutes, even if only to ask something.
3. Practise the build: "Adding to what Sam said — the same applies to renewals." It is the easiest entry there is.
4. Time your longest contribution. If it exceeded forty-five seconds, practise the thirty-second version.
5. Note the meetings where you stayed silent, and write down the actual reason. It is usually a specific person, not the topic.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| "Can I check one thing before we move on — are we assuming the budget is confirmed?"

| "Short point: I think the risk sits in the handover, not the build. Happy to say more if useful."

WATCH OUT

Speaking to be seen speaking is transparent and expensive. Comments that restate what was just said, or that are obviously about visibility, cost you more than silence would. Contribute something real, even if small.

JOURNAL

Which meeting do I stay silent in, and who is in the room?

DAY 72

DAY 72 OF 100

Run a Meeting That Respects Time

Focus: Purpose, structure, decisions, close.

Most meetings are badly run not through incompetence but through absence of structure: no stated purpose, no decision identified, no owner of the time. As a result, discussion expands to fill the slot and finishes without conclusions. Four small habits will make your meetings noticeably better than average, and people notice quickly.

LEARN

- **State the purpose and the decision in the first minute.** “By the end of this we need to have chosen a supplier.” Purpose without a decision produces discussion without end.
- **Own the time out loud.** “We have twenty minutes, ten on options and five on next steps.” Then enforce it, which is the part people avoid.
- **Manage the airtime.** Invite the quiet people by name, and interrupt the dominant ones politely. Both are your job if you called the meeting.
- **Close with the summary.** Decisions, actions with owners and dates, open questions. Two minutes, reserved deliberately.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. For your next meeting, write the purpose sentence and the decision needed. Send them in advance.
2. Open with both, plus the time plan.
3. Invite one quiet person by name: “Priya, you have done this before — what are we missing?”
4. Practise the polite interrupt: “Let me pause you there, I want to get Ana’s view before we run out of time.”
5. Reserve the last two minutes and deliver the closing summary. Send the recap within the hour.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Purpose: choose between the two suppliers. We have twenty minutes. Ten on the trade-offs, five on the decision, five on next steps.”

“We are not going to resolve this today. I am going to take it offline with Jon and come back Thursday with a recommendation.”

WATCH OUT

Rigid time-keeping can cut off the one conversation that mattered. If something important surfaces, say so explicitly and choose: extend, or park it with a named follow-up. Deciding openly is the difference between control and bureaucracy.

JOURNAL

Did my meeting end with clear decisions? Who did not speak, and why?

DAY 73

DAY 73 OF 100

The Status Update Nobody Dreads

Focus: Report in sixty seconds: status, progress, blockers, ask.

Round-the-table updates are where many people quietly damage their reputation: too long, too much detail, no headline, no ask. A crisp sixty-second update signals that you know what matters and that you respect everyone's time. Over a year, this one habit changes how senior people perceive your judgement.

LEARN

- **Status word first.** On track, at risk, blocked, done. Then the detail.
- **Two sentences of progress, in outcomes.** What is now true that was not true last week.
- **Name the blocker and the person who can fix it.** This is the entire reason the meeting exists.
- **Finish with your ask or an explicit “nothing needed.”** Both are useful; silence is not.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write your next real update in four lines: status, progress, blocker, ask.
2. Say it aloud and time it. Cut until it is under sixty seconds.
3. Remove every activity description and replace it with an outcome.
4. Practise the blocked version: “Blocked. I need X from Y by Wednesday, otherwise the date moves.”
5. Deliver it for real and note whether anyone asked for more detail. If they did, that is the system working correctly.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“On track. Two of three integrations are live and tested. Next week: the third, plus load testing. No blockers. Nothing needed from anyone here.”

“At risk, and it is a decision I need. If we cannot get sign-off by Thursday, the date moves to the eighth. That is the whole update.”

WATCH OUT

Do not use the update slot to demonstrate effort. Detailed accounts of how hard the week was read as either self-justification or poor prioritisation. Report the state of the work, not the state of you.

JOURNAL

How long was my last update? What could I have cut without losing anything?

DAY 74

DAY 74 OF 100

Ask Better Questions at Work

Focus: Ask in a way that gets answers and builds credibility.

Many people avoid asking questions because they fear looking ignorant, and instead spend hours guessing. Well-framed questions do the opposite of exposing you: they demonstrate that you have thought about the problem, they save everyone time, and they surface the assumption that would have caused the failure.

LEARN

- **Show your work first.** “I have read the spec and tried X. What I cannot work out is Y.” This converts a question into evidence of competence.
- **Ask about assumptions, not just facts.** “What are we assuming about the client's timeline?” is the highest-value question in most meetings.
- **Ask one question at a time and wait.** Stacked questions get partial answers.
- **Ask the dumb question when nobody else will.** Very often three other people did not understand either, and someone senior will thank you privately.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write the three questions you have been avoiding asking. For each, add the “what I have already tried” line.
2. Ask one of them today.
3. In your next meeting, ask one assumption question.
4. Practise the clarifying question that protects you later: “What does *done* look like for this?”
5. Note the answer to the question you were most afraid to ask. It is almost never as bad as anticipated.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I have read the brief twice and tried two approaches. I am stuck on how the two systems share the customer record — can you point me at whoever knows?”

“Before we commit: what are we assuming here that we have not verified?”

WATCH OUT

Asking questions you could answer yourself in five minutes of reading is a genuine cost to colleagues, and repeated use of it does damage your reputation. Do the reading, then ask the question the reading exposed.

JOURNAL

What question have I been avoiding? What is the cost of not asking it?

DAY 75

DAY 75 OF 100

Give Feedback That Lands

Focus: Be specific, timely, behavioural and forward-looking.

Most feedback fails in one of two ways: it is too vague to act on (“be more proactive”) or it is about the person rather than the behaviour (“you are disorganised”). Useful feedback describes a specific observable action, its effect, and what you would like instead. That version is hard to argue with and possible to act on.

LEARN

- **Behaviour, effect, request.** “In the client call you answered before Ana finished twice. She stopped contributing. Next time, hold your answer until she is done.”
- **Specific and recent.** Feedback about something two months ago is a complaint. Within a few days is coaching.
- **Skip the sandwich.** Praise-criticism-praise fools nobody and teaches people to distrust praise. Give both, separately and honestly.
- **Ask before you tell, when you can.** “How do you think that call went?” often produces the whole insight without you having to deliver it.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write one piece of real feedback you owe someone, in the behaviour-effect-request structure.
2. Check it: is the behaviour observable? Would a camera have recorded it? If not, rewrite it.
3. Remove every character judgement. Words like *lazy*, *negative*, *disorganised* have no place in it.
4. Rehearse the opening aloud: “Can I give you something on yesterday’s call? It is small and specific.”
5. Deliver it today or tomorrow. Then write down how they responded.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Can I give you one thing from the review? When the client asked about pricing, you said ‘I think so’ twice. He looked unsure afterwards. If you do not know, I would say ‘I will confirm today’ — it lands as more solid.”

“How do you think it went? ... And what would you do differently?”

WATCH OUT

Never give critical feedback in front of an audience, and never when you are still annoyed. Both turn coaching into humiliation, and the content of your message will be lost entirely behind the experience of receiving it.

JOURNAL

What feedback do I owe someone that I have been avoiding? What is the behaviour-effect-request version?

DAY 76

DAY 76 OF 100

Receive Feedback Without Defending

Focus: Listen, ask, thank, decide later.

How you take feedback determines whether you ever get it again. Defending, explaining or counter-attacking teaches people that feedback is expensive, and they stop — which means you lose the information you most need. The skill is separating the moment of receiving from the decision about what to do with it.

LEARN

- **Do not respond in the first ten seconds.** Breathe. The urge to explain is strongest at the start and almost always makes it worse.
- **Ask for the specific example.** “Can you give me an example?” turns vague criticism into something usable, and it is a legitimate question, not a defence.
- **Thank them, honestly.** Giving feedback is uncomfortable. Acknowledging that costs nothing and keeps the channel open.
- **Decide later.** You are not obliged to agree. Take it away, evaluate it, act on what is true. “Let me think about that” is a complete response.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write your default defensive move. Everyone has one: explaining context, listing constraints, pointing at someone else, going quiet and cold.
2. Rehearse the four-step response aloud: pause, “can you give me an example?”, “thank you — that is useful”, “let me think about it and come back to you.”
3. Ask someone for feedback today, specifically: “What is one thing I could do better in our meetings?”
4. When you get it, run the four steps. Do not explain, even once.
5. Write down what was true in it, twenty-four hours later, when the sting has gone.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “That is hard to hear and I think it is fair. Can you give me one more example so I know what to watch for?”

| “Thank you for telling me. I want to think about it properly rather than react now.”

WATCH OUT

Over-agreeing is also a defence. Collapsing into “you are right, I am terrible at this” ends the conversation as effectively as arguing, and it puts the other person in the position of reassuring you. Stay level.

JOURNAL

What is my defensive reflex? Did I manage to hold it today?

DAY 77

DAY 77 OF 100

Say No and Protect Your Yes

Focus: Decline clearly, kindly and without a fabricated excuse.

People who cannot say no become unreliable, because they take on more than they can deliver and then miss things quietly. A clear no, given early, protects your reputation far better than a reluctant yes followed by a late delivery. The structure is simple and it takes practice, because the discomfort is real.

LEARN

- **Acknowledge, decline, offer.** “I can see why this matters. I cannot take it on this month. What I can do is review the draft.”
- **Give a real reason, briefly.** “I have two deadlines this week” is enough. Long justifications invite negotiation.
- **The conditional yes is often the best answer.** “Yes, if the report moves to the twentieth” or “Yes, if we drop the newsletter.” This makes the trade-off visible instead of hidden.
- **Do not apologise repeatedly.** One acknowledgement is enough. Extended apology invites them to reopen the request.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. List three things you said yes to recently that you should have declined or renegotiated.
2. Write the acknowledge-decline-offer version of each.
3. Write two conditional yes sentences for requests you expect this week.
4. Say no to one thing today. It can be small: a meeting invitation, an optional task, a favour.
5. Note what actually happened afterwards. In almost every case, nothing.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I cannot take that on this month without dropping something else. If it is more important than the audit, I will swap them — your call.”

“No to Thursday, but yes to the following week if that still helps.”

WATCH OUT

Do not invent excuses. Fabricated reasons are easily checked, they collapse when the situation changes, and they train you to believe you need permission to decline. “I do not have capacity” is a complete and honest reason.

JOURNAL

What did I say no to today? What did I fear would happen, and what actually happened?

DAY 78

DAY 78 OF 100

Manage Up and Escalate Well

Focus: Give your manager what they need, and raise problems properly.

Managers are making decisions with incomplete information under time pressure. The people they trust most are the ones who make their job easier: no surprises, clear options, early warnings. Escalation is not admitting failure — done properly it is one of the strongest signals of judgement you can send.

LEARN

- **No surprises is the whole contract.** Bad news early, always. A manager blindsided in front of their own boss will remember it for years.
- **Bring options, not just problems.** “Here is the issue, here are two options, here is my recommendation, here is what I need from you.”
- **Learn their format.** Some want two lines, some want the detail, some want it verbally. Ask directly: “How do you prefer to get updates?”
- **Escalate the decision, not the emotion.** Name what you need: a decision, a resource, air cover, or simply that they should know.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write down what you think your manager most wants to know each week, then ask them whether you are right.
2. Take a current problem and write the escalation: issue, impact, two options, recommendation, what you need.
3. Practise the early warning: “This is not a problem yet, but I want you to know about it now rather than in two weeks.”
4. Ask your manager how they prefer to receive updates, and in what format.
5. Escalate one thing this week using the structure.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Flagging early: the supplier has gone quiet. Not urgent yet. If I have not heard by Friday, we should switch, which costs about two weeks. I will keep chasing — nothing needed from you today.”

“I need a decision from you rather than advice: A or B. My recommendation is B, because it protects the launch date.”

WATCH OUT

Escalating without having tried anything first, or escalating over someone's head without telling them, both damage trust badly. Try, document, tell the person, then escalate.

JOURNAL

What am I not telling my manager that they would want to know today?

DAY 79

DAY 79 OF 100

One-to-Ones and Career Conversations

Focus: Use your one-to-one as an agenda you own.

Most one-to-ones default to a status update, which is a waste of the only guaranteed time you have with your manager. The person who brings an agenda controls what the meeting is about. Two of those slots a quarter, used well, move your career more than a year of good work performed silently.

LEARN

- **Bring three items.** One thing you need, one thing you want them to know, one thing about your development.
- **Ask for specifics, not reassurance.** “What would make the difference between good and excellent in this role?” beats “am I doing OK?”
- **Talk about direction twice a year explicitly.** Where you want to be, what is missing, what would need to be true. Managers cannot act on ambitions they have not been told about.
- **Write it down and follow up.** Agreements from career conversations evaporate unless one of you records them. Be that one.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write the agenda for your next one-to-one: your ask, your update, your development item.
2. Write the three career questions you want answered this quarter.
3. Practise stating an ambition plainly: “I want to be leading a team within two years. What would need to be true?”
4. Send the agenda in advance. It changes the meeting before it starts.
5. Afterwards, send two lines confirming anything agreed.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Three things from me today: I need a decision on the contractor, I want to flag the client risk, and I would like ten minutes on what the next role looks like.”

“What is the one thing I could change that would make the biggest difference to how my work is seen?”

WATCH OUT

Do not turn every one-to-one into a promotion conversation. Raise direction deliberately, once or twice a year, with evidence. Constant pressure reads as impatience rather than ambition.

JOURNAL

What do I want in twelve months, and has my manager actually heard me say it?

DAY 80

DAY 80 OF 100

Interviews: Answer Like a Professional

Focus: Structure, evidence, and questions of your own.

Interviews reward communication more than any other professional situation, because the interviewer has almost no information except how you describe your work. Two candidates with identical experience can produce completely different impressions, and the difference is nearly always structure and specificity.

LEARN

- **Everything behavioural gets STAR.** Situation, task, action, result. Ninety seconds, with a number in the result.
- **Everything opinion-based gets PREP.** Point, reason, example, point. Sixty seconds.
- **Prepare six stories, not twenty answers.** Most questions can be answered with a well-chosen story from a bank of six: a success, a failure, a conflict, a leadership moment, a change of mind, a technical challenge.
- **Your questions are part of the assessment.** Ask about the actual work: what does success look like in six months, what has made previous people struggle, what would I own in the first month.

PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Write your six stories in STAR form. Cap each at 180 words.
2. Say each aloud and time it. Cut anything over ninety seconds.
3. Prepare PREP answers to three opinion questions likely in your field.
4. Write five questions of your own about the role, not the company's marketing.
5. Do a full mock: record yourself answering five questions in one take, then watch it and mark where you rambled.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | “What does someone doing this job well look like six months in?”
- | “What has made this role hard for people in the past?”

WATCH OUT

Memorised answers delivered verbatim sound worse than imperfect spontaneous ones. Learn the *structure* and the *facts* of each story, not the words, so it comes out fresh and responsive to the actual question asked.

JOURNAL

Which of my six stories is weakest? Is the gap in the action detail or in the result?

CHECKPOINT

Part Eight Review

You can now enter a meeting and be heard, run one that ends with decisions, report crisply, ask questions that build credibility, give and receive feedback without damage, decline clearly, escalate with options, own your one-to-ones and interview with structure. These are the mechanics of professional trust.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I speak in the first ten minutes of meetings.
- ☐ I state purpose, decision and time when I run a meeting.
- ☐ My updates are under sixty seconds and contain a status word.
- ☐ I ask assumption questions, and the dumb question when needed.
- ☐ I give feedback as behaviour, effect and request.
- ☐ I can receive criticism without explaining or collapsing.
- ☐ I have said a clear no, or a conditional yes, this part.
- ☐ I escalate with options and a recommendation.
- ☐ I bring a written agenda to my one-to-ones.
- ☐ I have six STAR stories ready and timed.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Ask a colleague or friend to interview you for fifteen minutes with a mix of behavioural and opinion questions. Record it. Afterwards, check three things: did every behavioural answer have a result with a number, did every opinion answer have a structure, and did any answer run past ninety seconds. Then ask them for one piece of feedback and practise receiving it with the four steps from Day 76.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Presence in meetings

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Clarity of updates

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Giving feedback

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Receiving feedback

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Boundaries and escalation

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If speaking up is still the hard part, the problem is usually a specific person in the room rather than the skill. Name them privately, then practise one prepared sentence in that meeting each week. Preparation beats confidence every time, and confidence follows afterwards.

PART NINE

Difficult Conversations, Persuasion and Conflict

DAYS 81-90

This is the part people buy books like this for, and it is deliberately placed ninth. Difficult conversations rely on everything before it: listening, breath control, plain language, structure and the ability to hold a pause. What is added here is a set of scripts for raising problems, staying calm when provoked, disagreeing without damage, apologising properly, persuading honestly and negotiating everyday asks.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Be assertive rather than passive or aggressive, with language you have rehearsed.
- Open a difficult conversation in a way the other person can hear.
- Stay physically and verbally calm when you are provoked.
- Disagree strongly without damaging the relationship.
- Apologise in a way that repairs rather than defends.

DAY 81

DAY 81 OF 100

Assertive, Not Passive or Aggressive

Focus: State what you need directly, while respecting the other person.

Passive communication protects the relationship at the cost of your needs; aggressive communication does the reverse. Assertiveness is the third option that most people were never taught: saying clearly what you want, what you will do, and what you will not, without attacking or apologising. It is learnable as language, which is the fastest route in.

LEARN

- **Passive:** hinting, hoping, agreeing then resenting, “whatever you think.” Costs: unmet needs, silent resentment, eventual explosion.
- **Aggressive:** blaming, labelling, raising volume, absolutes like *always* and *never*. Costs: compliance for a while, then avoidance.
- **Assertive:** “I need X. I can do Y. I cannot do Z.” First person, specific, no character judgements, no apology for having needs.
- **Volume and pace stay level.** Assertive content delivered at aggressive volume is heard as aggression. Slower and quieter is what makes it land.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write down three recent situations where you were passive and three where you were aggressive.
2. Rewrite each in assertive language using “I need...”, “I can...”, “I am not able to...”
3. Say them aloud at deliberately lower volume and slower pace than feels natural.
4. Use one assertive statement today in a real situation, however small.
5. Note the outcome. Passive people consistently overestimate the negative reaction to assertiveness.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I need the figures by Wednesday to hit the deadline. If they arrive Thursday, the report moves to Monday. Which works better for you?”

“I am not able to stay late tonight. I can start early tomorrow if that helps.”

WATCH OUT

There are contexts where directness carries real risk: steep hierarchies, some cultures, and situations involving your own safety or job security. Assertiveness is a tool, not an obligation. Choose deliberately, and soften the framing without abandoning the content.

JOURNAL

Where am I habitually passive? What is one assertive sentence I could have used today?

DAY 82

DAY 82 OF 100

Open a Difficult Conversation

Focus: The first thirty seconds decide how the rest goes.

Most difficult conversations are lost in the opening, because the opening tells the other person whether they are about to be attacked. If they feel accused, everything afterwards is defence, and no information passes in either direction. A well-designed opening does three things: names the topic, states your intention, and invites them in.

LEARN

- **Ask for the conversation.** “Can we talk about yesterday’s meeting? Twenty minutes today or tomorrow?” Ambushing people guarantees defensiveness.
- **Name your intention explicitly.** “I want us to work well together, and something is getting in the way.” People cannot infer good intent; tell them.
- **Describe, do not accuse.** State the observable facts, then your reaction as yours: “When the deadline moved without a message, I was left explaining it to the client.”
- **Hand over early.** Finish the opening with a genuine question and then be quiet. Their view in the first two minutes changes everything you say next.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Choose a real conversation you have been avoiding. Write the opening in four parts: the request, the intention, the facts, the question.
2. Read it aloud. Remove every *always*, *never*, *you make me*, and every character judgement.
3. Time it. Your opening should be thirty to forty-five seconds. Longer becomes a monologue.
4. Rehearse it twice out loud, then once with the three low breaths from Day 5 beforehand.
5. Have the conversation this week. Write down what they said in the first two minutes.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Can we talk about the handover? I want this to work well, and at the moment it is causing problems downstream. Twice this month I found out about changes from the client rather than from you. I want to understand what is happening at your end.”

WATCH OUT

Do not open with “we need to talk” and then wait a day. The gap produces anxiety and rehearsed defence. Ask for the conversation and hold it soon — ideally within a day.

JOURNAL

Which conversation am I avoiding? What is the exact opening sentence?

DAY 83

DAY 83 OF 100

DESC: A Script for Raising an Issue

Focus: Describe, Express, Specify, Consequences.

When you are anxious, structure is what stops you either softening the point into invisibility or overshooting into attack. DESC is a four-part script that keeps you factual, owns your reaction, makes a specific request and states the consequence — all in under a minute. It works for colleagues, suppliers, landlords and family.

LEARN

- **Describe:** the behaviour, factually, without adjectives. “The last three reports arrived after the deadline.”
- **Express:** your reaction, owned. “I end up rewriting them at night, and I am frustrated.” Not “you make me...”
- **Specify:** exactly what you want. “I need them by Thursday midday, or a message by Wednesday if they will be late.”
- **Consequences:** the positive first. “Then I can review properly and you get feedback in time.” Negative consequences only if you can and will follow through.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Take one real issue and write all four parts. Keep the whole script under a hundred words.
2. Check Describe for adjectives and Express for blame. Both are the usual failure points.
3. Make Specify concrete: a time, a number, a behaviour. “Be more communicative” is not a request.
4. Rehearse it aloud three times, then have someone play the other person and push back once.
5. Use it this week and note which part they responded to.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“The last three reports came in after the deadline. [D] I have ended up rewriting them late at night, and I am frustrated. [E] I need them by Thursday midday, or a heads-up on Wednesday if they will be late. [S] If that works, I can give you proper feedback instead of rushing it. [C]”

WATCH OUT

Do not state a consequence you will not enforce. An empty threat converts a serious conversation into a bluff you have to keep repeating, and it teaches the other person that your words do not mean anything.

JOURNAL

Which part of DESC was hardest to write? That is usually the part I avoid in real life.

DAY 84

DAY 84 OF 100

Observation, Not Judgement

Focus: Separate what happened from what you concluded about it.

Almost every conflict escalates at the same point: someone states an interpretation as if it were a fact. “You do not care about this project” is a conclusion; “the last two meetings were missed” is an observation. People will argue with conclusions forever, and they cannot argue with observations — which is why this distinction is the single most useful de-escalation tool available.

LEARN

- **Observation:** what a camera would have recorded. Times, words, counts, actions.
- **Judgement:** what you concluded. Lazy, uninterested, rude, deliberate. Always contestable, always inflammatory.
- **State the observation, then own the interpretation as yours.** “When I did not hear back for three days, I assumed it was not a priority. Was that right?”
- **Watch the absolutes.** *Always, never, constantly, every time.* These are almost never literally true, and they invite counter-examples instead of solutions.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write five sentences about a current annoyance exactly as they appear in your head.
2. Sort each into observation or judgement. Most will be judgements.
3. Rewrite each judgement as an observation plus a stated interpretation you own.
4. Remove every absolute and replace it with a count: “twice this month” instead of “always.”
5. Use one observation-plus-interpretation in a real conversation today.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Instead of “you never listen to me in meetings”: “In the last two meetings I was interrupted before finishing. I took it as my input not being wanted, and I would rather check than assume.”

WATCH OUT

Observation language can be weaponised. Delivered coldly, as a documented case against someone, it is worse than plain complaint. The point is to open a conversation, not to build a file.

JOURNAL

Which judgement have I been carrying about someone? What is the observation underneath it?

DAY 85

DAY 85 OF 100

Stay Calm When You Are Triggered

Focus: Buy thirty seconds before you respond.

Under threat your body prepares to fight or leave: heart rate rises, breathing shortens, and the part of your brain responsible for careful language becomes markedly less available. Everyone has said something they regretted in that state. You cannot prevent the reaction, but you can interrupt the sequence between the reaction and your mouth.

LEARN

- **Know your early signals.** Hot face, tight chest, faster speech, an urge to interrupt. The signal comes before the words; that is your window.
- **Breathe out longer than you breathe in.** The long exhale is the fastest physiological brake available. Two cycles is often enough.
- **Buy time explicitly.** “Give me a moment”, “I want to think before I answer”, “can we take five minutes?” All are legitimate and read as composure.
- **Ask a question instead of making a statement.** Questions keep you in the conversation while your capacity for careful language returns.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write down your three physical early-warning signals. Be specific about where you feel them.
2. Write your three time-buying sentences and say them aloud until they are automatic.
3. Practise the reset: two long exhales, feet on the floor, one question. Rehearse it now, calm, so it is available when you are not.
4. Recall a recent moment you reacted badly. Write what you would say now, with the reset.
5. Use the reset once today, in any mildly irritating moment. Small reps build the reflex.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

| “I want to give you a proper answer rather than a fast one. Give me a minute.”

| “I am finding this difficult and I would rather not say something I regret. Can we pick it up after lunch?”

WATCH OUT

Walking out without explanation reads as contempt and does real damage. If you need to leave, say why and name when you will return: “I need twenty minutes. I will come back at three.” Then come back.

JOURNAL

What are my early signals? Where did I feel them today, and what did I do?

DAY 86

DAY 86 OF 100

Disagree Without Damage

Focus: Attack the problem, never the person.

Teams that never disagree make poor decisions, so the ability to disagree well is a professional asset rather than a risk. The trick is separating the idea from the person who holds it, and making it obvious that you are trying to get to a better answer rather than to win. Done well, strong disagreement increases trust.

LEARN

- **Acknowledge first, genuinely.** “I can see why that is attractive — it is the fastest option.” Then disagree.
- **Disagree with the idea, in the third person.** “The plan assumes the client responds in a week” not “you always assume the best case.”
- **Bring the criterion, not just the objection.** “If we optimise for the launch date, A wins; if for support cost, B wins. Which are we optimising for?” This turns a clash into a shared question.
- **Say what would change your mind.** It signals honesty and invites the same in return. If nothing would, you are not in a discussion.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Take a current disagreement. Write the acknowledgement sentence first, and make it true.
2. State your objection about the idea, with no reference to the person's character or pattern of behaviour.
3. Write the criterion question: what are we actually optimising for?
4. Write what would change your mind, specifically.
5. Use the full sequence in a real disagreement this week and note how the temperature differed.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I can see why that is appealing, and I disagree — here is where I think it breaks. If the client takes two weeks rather than one, we miss the window entirely. What am I missing?”

“I would change my mind if we could get written confirmation by Friday. Can we?”

WATCH OUT

Do not use “with respect”, “no offence” or “I am just being honest” as a licence. Everyone knows these phrases mean the opposite is coming, and they raise defences before your point arrives.

JOURNAL

What would change my mind on the thing I currently disagree about? If nothing, why not?

DAY 87

DAY 87 OF 100

Apologise and Repair

Focus: Own it plainly, without explanation or self-defence.

A real apology is one of the fastest trust-repair mechanisms that exists, and most people ruin theirs by attaching a justification. “I am sorry, but I was under a lot of pressure” is not an apology; it is a defence wearing an apology's clothes, and the listener hears only the second half.

LEARN

- **Name what you did, specifically.** “I sent the email to the whole group instead of just to you.” Vague apologies feel evasive.
- **Acknowledge the effect on them.** “That put you in an awkward position in front of your team.” This is the part that does the repair work.
- **No *but*.** Explanation belongs in a separate conversation, later, if they ask for it. Attached to an apology it cancels it.
- **Say what you will do differently, then do it.** Repair is behaviour. A second apology for the same thing is worth almost nothing.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write an apology you owe. Four parts: what you did, the effect, no excuse, what changes.
2. Read it back and delete every justification and every *but*.
3. Check the effect sentence: does it describe their experience rather than your intention?
4. Deliver it in person or by voice if you can. Written apologies are read in the recipient's mood.
5. Note their response. Genuine apologies frequently produce an immediate change in the relationship.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I got that wrong. I committed you to a date without checking, and you had to work the weekend because of it. That was not fair. From now on I will confirm with you before agreeing dates.”

WATCH OUT

Over-apologising for everything devalues the currency. If you say sorry twenty times a day, your real apology carries no weight. Reserve *sorry* for actual harm, and use “thank you for waiting” for the rest.

JOURNAL

What apology do I owe? What is the excuse I keep wanting to attach to it?

DAY 88

DAY 88 OF 100

Persuade: Credibility, Logic, Feeling

Focus: Use all three appeals, in the order the audience needs.

Persuasion has been described the same way for two and a half thousand years: credibility, reasoning and emotion. Most people over-rely on whichever one comes naturally — technical people on logic, salespeople on feeling — and then find their strongest argument bounces off. The fix is to notice which appeal is missing and add it deliberately.

LEARN

- **Credibility:** why they should believe you. Experience, evidence, track record, honesty about uncertainty. Admitting the weakness in your own case builds more credibility than hiding it.
- **Logic:** the reasoning and the numbers. Necessary, and almost never sufficient on its own.
- **Feeling:** why it matters, told through one specific person or consequence. This is what makes people act rather than agree.
- **Address their concern, not your case.** The most persuasive move is showing that you have understood their objection better than they expected.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Take something you need to persuade someone of. Write one paragraph for each appeal: credibility, logic, feeling.
2. Identify which appeal you naturally lead with, and which you have neglected.
3. Write the strongest version of their objection, in their words. Then answer it.
4. Add one specific human consequence — a named person, a real case, a concrete outcome.
5. Deliver the case aloud in ninety seconds using all three appeals.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"I have run three of these migrations, and two of them slipped for the same reason. [credibility] The numbers say we save nine days by doing the data work first. [logic] And it means the support team is not taking angry calls over Christmas again. [feeling]"

WATCH OUT

Emotional appeals that exaggerate or manufacture urgency are manipulation, and they are usually detected — if not immediately then afterwards, when the predicted catastrophe does not occur. Use real stakes only.

JOURNAL

Which appeal do I neglect? What is the strongest version of the other side's objection?

DAY 89

DAY 89 OF 100

Handle Objections and Hard Questions

Focus: Acknowledge, answer, check — without getting defensive.

Hard questions are not attacks; they are usually the sign of someone taking your idea seriously. But they arrive with adrenaline, and the untrained response is to defend, over-explain or dismiss. A three-step pattern keeps you composed and, crucially, makes the questioner feel taken seriously, which is often what they actually wanted.

LEARN

- **Acknowledge the legitimacy of the question.** “That is the right question to ask”, said honestly, drops the temperature immediately.
- **Answer briefly.** Long answers signal anxiety. If you do not know, say so and commit to a time: “I do not know. I will find out today.”
- **Check it landed.** “Does that answer it?” Prevents the same objection resurfacing three times.
- **Separate the question from the tone.** Hostile delivery does not make a question invalid. Answer the content and leave the tone alone unless it becomes a pattern.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write the five hardest questions about your current project or proposal.
2. Write a two-sentence answer to each. Anything longer needs cutting.
3. For the one you cannot answer, practise the honest version: “I do not know yet. Here is how I will find out, and by when.”
4. Have someone fire all five at you rapidly. Note which one made you defensive; that one needs more work.
5. Practise the acknowledge-answer-check pattern until the acknowledgement is automatic.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Fair challenge. The short answer is we tested it at half that volume and it held; above that we do not know. Does that answer it, or do you want the detail?”

“I do not know. I would rather tell you that than guess. I will have an answer by Thursday.”

WATCH OUT

Never answer a question you were not asked because it is the one you prepared for. Everyone notices, and it converts a reasonable question into suspicion that you are avoiding something.

JOURNAL

Which question makes me defensive? What is the calm two-sentence answer?

DAY 90

DAY 90 OF 100

Negotiate Everyday Asks

Focus: Prepare, ask for more than the minimum, and trade rather than concede.

Most negotiation is not a formal deal; it is a deadline, a salary, a scope, a price, a division of work. The people who do well are not aggressive — they are prepared. They know what they want, what they will settle for, what they will do instead, and they trade rather than simply giving ground.

LEARN

- **Prepare three numbers:** your ideal, your acceptable minimum, and your alternative if there is no agreement. The alternative is where your confidence comes from.
- **Ask for more than your minimum, and justify it.** An unexplained number invites haggling; a reasoned one invites discussion.
- **Trade, do not concede.** “I can do the earlier date if we drop the second review.” Every concession should be paired with something.
- **Ask about their constraints.** “What is driving the date?” Most agreements are unlocked by discovering the constraint, not by pushing harder.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Choose a real ask: a deadline, a budget, a scope, a price, a division of chores.
2. Write your three numbers: ideal, minimum, alternative.
3. Write your opening ask with its one-line justification.
4. Write two trades you could offer instead of conceding.
5. Make the ask this week. Afterwards, note whether you opened at your ideal or drifted straight to your minimum.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I am asking for the twentieth rather than the twelfth. Eight extra days lets us test properly, which is what went wrong last time. If the twelfth is fixed, I can hit it by dropping the reporting module — which would you prefer?”

“What is driving that date? If I understand the constraint I can probably work with it.”

WATCH OUT

Do not open with your minimum in the hope of appearing reasonable. It leaves you nowhere to go, and it commonly reads as your ideal anyway — so you get negotiated down from a number you could not afford to lose.

JOURNAL

What am I currently accepting that I have never actually asked to change?

CHECKPOINT

Part Nine Review

You now have language for the situations most people avoid: assertive statements, a rehearsed opening for difficult conversations, the DESC script, observation instead of judgement, a physical reset for when you are triggered, a way to disagree that builds trust, a real apology, three appeals for persuasion, a pattern for hard questions, and a preparation routine for everyday negotiation.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I can tell the difference between passive, aggressive and assertive in my own speech.
- ☐ I have opened one difficult conversation deliberately this part.
- ☐ I have written and used a DESC script.
- ☐ I can state an observation without a judgement attached.
- ☐ I know my physical early-warning signals and I have a reset.
- ☐ I have disagreed with an idea without criticising a person.
- ☐ I have apologised without attaching an excuse.
- ☐ I can name which persuasive appeal I neglect.
- ☐ I have answers to the five hardest questions about my work.
- ☐ I have prepared and made one negotiated ask.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

Have the difficult conversation you have been avoiding. Prepare it properly: the four-part opening, DESC for the issue, observations rather than judgements, and your reset ready. Afterwards write three things — what they said that you did not expect, which part of your preparation helped most, and what you would do differently. If there is genuinely no such conversation available, role-play it with a partner instead.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Assertiveness

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Staying calm under provocation

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Disagreeing well

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Apology and repair

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Persuasion and negotiation

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If these still feel out of reach, scale down rather than giving up: use DESC on a minor annoyance, be assertive about something trivial, negotiate a small deadline. And note the limits honestly — if a situation involves bullying, harassment or a threat to your safety, this is not a communication skills problem and should go to HR, a union, or a lawyer.

PART TEN

Speaking to Groups, and Making It Last

DAYS 91-100

Public speaking is not a separate skill; it is everything you have already trained, done standing up, with more preparation and higher stakes. These final ten days cover designing a talk, opening and closing it, using slides properly, rehearsing efficiently, managing fear, speaking without preparation, and handling questions. The last two days are the capstone talk and the plan that keeps all of this alive after Day 100.

BY THE END OF THIS PART YOU CAN

- Design a clear twenty-minute talk in under an hour.
- Open in a way that earns attention and close in a way that is remembered.
- Rehearse efficiently, out loud, without memorising a script.
- Manage physical fear well enough to perform anyway.
- Speak coherently for two minutes on almost anything, with no preparation.

DAY 91

DAY 91 OF 100

Design a Talk in Twenty Minutes

Focus: One message, three points, a close — written before any slides.

Most bad talks are bad because they were designed in slide software. Opening a deck first turns a talk into a list of topics with no argument. Designing on paper forces the only question that matters: what is the one thing you want this audience to remember, and what are the three things that get them there.

LEARN

- **Write the one-sentence message first.** “If they remember one thing, it should be...” If you cannot write it, you are not ready to build anything.
- **Then the audience question:** what do they already believe, what do they care about, and what will they resist? Design against those answers.
- **Three points, each with evidence and one example.** Three sections is the right shape for anything from five to thirty minutes.
- **Time it honestly.** Roughly two minutes per point of substance, plus opening and close. Twenty minutes of content in a twenty-minute slot means you overrun.

PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Pick a real talk you could plausibly give: a team briefing, a conference talk, a training session, a family speech.
2. Write the one-sentence message. Rewrite it three times until it is under twenty words.
3. Write three points that support it. Under each, one piece of evidence and one example.
4. Write the opening and closing lines. Nothing else.
5. Say the whole structure aloud from your one page of notes, without slides, and time it.

WATCH OUT

Do not include material because it is interesting or because you have it. Anything that does not serve the one sentence must come out, however good it is. That is the hardest and most valuable editing decision in speaking.

JOURNAL

What is the one sentence I want remembered? Did any of my three points fail to serve it?

DAY 92

DAY 92 OF 100

Openings That Earn Attention

Focus: Skip the housekeeping and start with something real.

Your first fifteen seconds set the audience's expectations for the whole talk, and most speakers waste them on their own name, an apology, a technical complaint or a slide of an agenda. Attention is highest at the start and it will never be that high again. Spend it on the most interesting thing you have.

LEARN

- **Four openings that work:** a specific story; a surprising number; a real question; a sharp statement of the problem.
- **Say your name after, not before.** They will not remember it at second five anyway, and it is not why they are listening.
- **Never apologise or complain at the start.** “Sorry, I only had a day to prepare”, “this is not really my area”, and technology grumbles all discount your own content before it starts.
- **Signpost after the hook.** Hook first, then the map: “Three things, twelve minutes.”

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write four different openings for your Day 91 talk: story, number, question, problem statement.
2. Say each aloud and time it. Fifteen to thirty seconds each.
3. Record all four. Play them back and pick the one that makes you want to keep listening.
4. Rehearse the chosen one until you can deliver it without notes, looking up.
5. Test it on one person and ask what they expected the talk to be about afterwards.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Last March a customer waited eleven days for a refund of four pounds. It cost us ninety pounds to process. I want to talk about why, and what we do about it.”

“Sixty percent of the tickets we handle are the same three questions. Three things, twelve minutes, and one decision I will ask you for at the end.”

WATCH OUT

Avoid the borrowed inspirational quotation, the dictionary definition and “today I am going to talk about.” All three are recognisable as filler and they signal that nothing original is coming.

JOURNAL

Which of my four openings was strongest? Why did that one work better than the others?

DAY 93

DAY 93 OF 100

Endings That Stick

Focus: Finish on your message and one clear action — not on questions.

People remember the end of a talk more than the middle, and most speakers throw it away by trailing off into “so, yeah, that is it — any questions?” A designed ending takes thirty seconds to deliver and completely changes what the audience takes away. Write it, learn it, and land it.

LEARN

- **Signal the close.** “Let me finish with this.” Attention rises measurably at those words.
- **Restate the one sentence.** The same message from the start, in slightly different words.
- **Name the action.** One specific thing you want them to do, decide or notice. Vague inspiration produces nothing.
- **Take questions *before* your final line, if you can.** Then close properly, so the talk ends on your message rather than on whatever the last question was.

PRACTICE TODAY — 18 MINUTES

1. Write the closing thirty seconds of your talk: signal, message restated, action.
2. Rehearse it until you can deliver it without notes. This and the opening are the only two parts worth learning almost word for word.
3. Practise the deliberate stop: deliver the last line, hold eye contact, and stay silent. Do not add anything.
4. Practise the question-then-close order aloud so the sequence is familiar.
5. Record the ending and check whether your voice fell at the end or trailed upward.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“Let me finish with this. Sixty percent of our tickets are three questions we already know the answers to. If you take one thing away: fix the help page before hiring anyone else. That is what I am asking for.”

WATCH OUT

Do not end with “thank you” as the whole close, and do not end with a questions slide left on screen. Both leave the audience holding nothing. Say your last line, then thank them.

JOURNAL

What is the one action I want my audience to take? Is it specific enough to do tomorrow?

DAY 94

DAY 94 OF 100

Slides That Support, Not Compete

Focus: Design slides that cannot be read instead of you.

Slides full of text force the audience to choose between reading and listening. They read, because reading is faster, and then you are narrating something they have already finished. Slides should carry what words cannot: an image, a number, a shape, a comparison. Everything else belongs in your mouth or in a handout.

LEARN

- **One idea per slide.** If it needs a second idea, it needs a second slide. Slides are free.
- **Six words or a picture.** Big type, few words. If someone can read your slide in under three seconds, it is working.
- **Never read your slides aloud.** It is the single most common speaking mistake and it makes both you and the slide redundant.
- **Separate the deck from the document.** If people need detail, write a document and send it. A slide deck that works as a document works as neither.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Take a deck you have used. Count the words on the busiest slide. Anything over thirty is a document, not a slide.
2. Rebuild three slides with a maximum of six words each, or one image plus a number.
3. Move the deleted content into your spoken notes or a separate written document.
4. Practise talking through the rebuilt slides without reading them.
5. Add one blank or black slide where you want full attention on you. It is startlingly effective.

WATCH OUT

Do not put your notes on the slides for your own comfort. Use paper notes or the speaker view. Using the audience's screen as your prompt is a choice to make the talk worse for them so it is easier for you.

JOURNAL

How many words on my busiest slide? What did I move off the slides and into speech?

DAY 95

DAY 95 OF 100

Rehearse Like a Professional

Focus: Out loud, standing, on your feet, three times.

Reading your slides through silently is not rehearsal. Speaking aloud recruits your breath, your mouth and your memory in the way the actual performance will, and it is the only way to find out how long the talk really is. Three full spoken run-throughs puts you ahead of most speakers you will ever share a stage with.

LEARN

- **Three run-throughs, minimum.** The first is a mess, the second finds the structure, the third is close to real. Nearly everyone stops after the first.
- **Stand up and use your voice at full volume.** Rehearsing seated and quietly trains a delivery you will not use.
- **Do not memorise the words.** Memorise the structure, the opening and the closing. A memorised script collapses at the first interruption and sounds recited.
- **Rehearse the transitions specifically.** Beginnings and endings of sections are where speakers lose their place; practise those joins on their own.

PRACTICE TODAY — 25 MINUTES

1. Run your talk out loud, standing, once. Time it. Do not stop to fix anything.
2. Note the three places it fell apart, and fix only those.
3. Run it a second time, timed. Then a third, recorded on video.
4. Watch the recording once on mute for body and once with eyes closed for voice.
5. Practise the transitions alone, five times each: “That is the problem. Now the options.”

WATCH OUT

Over-rehearsing into a fixed script is a real risk. If you start recognising exact sentences, stop and change your notes to key words only. Fluent improvisation within a firm structure always beats recitation.

JOURNAL

How long was my talk on the first run compared with the third? Where did it break down?

DAY 96

DAY 96 OF 100

Manage Stage Fear

Focus: Perform well while still feeling nervous.

The goal is not to eliminate nerves — experienced performers still get them, and the physical arousal is useful. The goal is to stop the fear from degrading your delivery. That is achieved through preparation, a physical routine, and reinterpreting the sensations rather than fighting them.

LEARN

- **Preparation is the largest single factor.** Most stage fear is unrehearsed-talk fear, and it responds to three run-throughs more than to any mental technique.
- **Reframe the arousal.** Fear and excitement share the same physical signals. Telling yourself “I am excited” is more effective than trying to calm down, because it matches what your body is actually doing.
- **Have a physical routine.** Long exhales, shoulder drop, feet grounded, jaw loose, one glass of water. The routine gives your nerves a job.
- **Learn the first thirty seconds cold.** The riskiest moment is the start; if the opening is automatic, your body settles within half a minute.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write your pre-talk routine as a checklist: five long exhales, shoulder drops, tongue twister, opening line twice, water.
2. Rehearse your first thirty seconds until it is completely automatic.
3. Practise the reframe out loud: “this is excitement, and it means I care.”
4. Deliberately expose yourself to a small dose of nerves this week: ask a question at a large meeting, or speak up in an unfamiliar group.
5. Write down what you fear specifically. Usually it is a concrete scenario — forgetting, a hostile question, going blank — and each has a practical countermeasure.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

If you go blank: “Let me come back to that — the important part is this.” Then continue from your notes.

If your voice shakes at the start: pause, breathe out, and say “Let me start that again.” Audiences are entirely forgiving of this.

WATCH OUT

Alcohol and beta-blockers are not a strategy, and telling an audience how nervous you are transfers your discomfort to them. If fear of speaking is severe enough to affect your work or health, that is worth taking to a professional — it responds well to treatment.

JOURNAL

What specifically do I fear? What is the practical countermeasure for it?

DAY 97

DAY 97 OF 100

Impromptu Speaking

Focus: Buy two seconds, pick a structure, speak for ninety.

“Can you say a few words?” is the moment people fear most, and it is entirely trainable, because the difficulty is not knowledge — it is the absence of a container. If you have three structures memorised, you can speak coherently on almost anything with two seconds of preparation.

LEARN

- **Buy the time.** “Good question — give me a second.” Two seconds of silence is invisible to the audience and enormous for you.
- **Pick one of three structures.** PREP (point, reason, example, point); Past-Present-Future; or Problem-Solution-Benefit. Any of them will hold ninety seconds.
- **One point, one example.** Impromptu speaking fails through trying to cover everything. Say one thing well.
- **End deliberately.** Land a closing sentence and stop. Most impromptu speaking dies of trailing off rather than of running out of content.

PRACTICE TODAY — 22 MINUTES

1. Write the three structures on a card and learn them.
2. Have someone give you five random topics. For each: two seconds of silence, pick a structure, speak for ninety seconds. Record it.
3. Do five more on work topics: a project, a decision, a risk, a colleague's work, a lesson learned.
4. Play back two of them. Check whether the structure was audible to a listener.
5. Practise the closing sentence: “So the short version is...” Use it to land every one.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“That is a good question — give me a second. [pause] Where we were six months ago, where we are now, and what I think happens next.”

“So the short version is: the process works, the handover does not, and that is where I would spend the money.”

WATCH OUT

Do not start speaking to buy thinking time. Filling the first twenty seconds with waffle while you work out your answer is far more visible than two seconds of silence, and it commits you to whatever direction you accidentally started in.

JOURNAL

Which structure comes most naturally to me under pressure?

DAY 98

DAY 98 OF 100

Handle Q&A With Confidence

Focus: Run the question session rather than surviving it.

Q&A is where credibility is won or lost, because it is unscripted and the audience knows it. It is also the part almost nobody rehearses. A handful of habits — repeating the question, answering briefly, admitting what you do not know, managing the difficult questioner — turns it from a threat into the most persuasive part of your talk.

LEARN

- **Repeat or rephrase the question.** It buys thinking time, ensures the room heard it, and lets you frame it fairly before answering.
- **Answer in under thirty seconds where possible.** Long answers reduce the number of questions and signal anxiety.
- **“I do not know” is a strong answer** when paired with a commitment: “I will find out and send it round tomorrow.” Bluffing is always eventually detected.
- **Manage the monopolist kindly.** “Let me take one more from someone else and come back to you if we have time.” Then move your eyes elsewhere.

PRACTICE TODAY — 20 MINUTES

1. Write the ten questions you would least like to be asked about your talk.
2. Write a thirty-second answer to each. Practise the three hardest aloud.
3. Practise the repeat-the-question habit until it is automatic.
4. Practise the honest non-answer and the deferral line.
5. Have someone role-play a hostile questioner. Practise answering the content and ignoring the tone.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“So the question is whether this works at ten times the volume. Honest answer: we have tested to three times, and above that I do not know. I would rather say that than guess.”

“That is a bigger discussion than we have time for — can we take it after? I want to make sure others get a question in.”

WATCH OUT

Never fight a hostile questioner in front of the room. Even when you win, the audience remembers a speaker who argued with an attendee. Answer briefly, offer to continue afterwards, and move on.

JOURNAL

Which question do I most fear? What is my honest thirty-second answer to it?

DAY 99

DAY 99 OF 100

Deliver Your Capstone Talk

Focus: Give a real five-minute talk to real people.

Ninety-eight days of practice needs a test that matters. A live talk to actual humans, recorded, is the closest thing to an exam this course has — and it is where you find out that the individual skills have become a single competence rather than a list.

LEARN

- **Real audience, however small.** Three colleagues, a team meeting, a family gathering, a community group, a video call. Two people is enough; zero is not.
- **Five to ten minutes, with questions.** Long enough to require structure, short enough to prepare properly.
- **Record it.** This is the recording you will compare with Day 1, and it is the whole point of having made the first one.
- **Ask for one specific piece of feedback.** “What was the one thing you remember?” tells you whether your message survived.

PRACTICE TODAY — 40 MINUTES

1. Finalise the talk you designed on Day 91: one message, three points, designed opening and close, minimal slides.
2. Run it aloud three times, standing. Time it.
3. Run your pre-talk routine, then deliver it live to a real audience. Record it.
4. Take questions using the Day 98 habits.
5. Ask two people: what is the one thing you remember, and what one thing would you change?

WATCH OUT

Do not postpone this until conditions are ideal. A five-minute talk to three colleagues this week is worth infinitely more than a perfect conference talk you never give. Book it before you finish today.

JOURNAL

What did people say they remembered? Was it the message I intended?

DAY 100

DAY 100 OF 100

Build Your Next Hundred Days

Focus: Measure what changed, then design the maintenance plan.

Skills that are not practised decay, and communication decays quietly — you do not notice the fillers returning or the pauses shortening. Today you measure the difference honestly, keep the three habits that carry the most weight, and choose the next two skills to work on. Then the course is finished and the practice is not.

LEARN

- **Compare, do not remember.** Re-record the Day 1 question and listen to both. Memory will underestimate the change; the recordings will not.
- **Keep three habits, not thirty.** The pause, the one-sentence intent and the weekly recording carry more than the rest combined.
- **Choose two skills for the next hundred days.** Two, chosen for cost to you, with a specific weekly drill for each.
- **Build in one repeating real-world commitment.** A monthly talk, a weekly recap, a difficult conversation you stop postponing. Habits survive when they are attached to obligations, not intentions.

PRACTICE TODAY — 35 MINUTES

1. Re-record the Day 1 answer: “What do you do, and what are you working on right now?” One take, sixty seconds.
2. Listen to Day 1 and Day 100 back to back. Write down three specific audible differences.
3. Re-score the eight areas from Day 1 out of ten. Compare with your original numbers.
4. Read your journal from the beginning. Note the entries where something visibly shifted.
5. Write your next hundred days on one page: three habits to keep, two skills to build with a weekly drill each, one repeating real-world commitment, and the date you will re-measure.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

“I am going to keep three things: a two-second pause before I answer, one sentence of intent before anything important, and a sixty-second recording every Sunday.”

WATCH OUT

Do not treat Day 100 as an ending. The most common outcome after finishing a course like this is a quiet slide back to the starting point over six months, simply because nothing was scheduled. Put the next drill in your calendar before you close the book.

JOURNAL

What are the three audible differences between Day 1 and Day 100? And what are my next two skills?

CHECKPOINT

Part Ten Review

You can design, open, rehearse and deliver a talk; you can speak without preparation; you can handle questions; and you have measured the difference between Day 1 and Day 100 with evidence rather than memory. The last day is the important one: the plan that keeps this from fading.

SELF-CHECK — TICK ONLY WHAT IS TRUE

- ☐ I have a one-sentence message for my talk and three points that serve it.
- ☐ I have written and rehearsed a designed opening and closing.
- ☐ My slides have six words or fewer, or an image.
- ☐ I have run a talk aloud, standing, at least three times.
- ☐ I have a pre-talk physical routine and my first thirty seconds are automatic.
- ☐ I can speak for ninety seconds on a random topic using one of three structures.
- ☐ I have prepared answers to my ten hardest questions.
- ☐ I have delivered a real talk to a real audience and recorded it.
- ☐ I have compared my Day 1 and Day 100 recordings.
- ☐ I have written my next hundred days on one page.

CONSOLIDATION DRILL

This is the final consolidation. Put four things in one place: your Day 100 recording, your re-scored eight areas, your one-page next-hundred-days plan, and the date in your calendar when you will re-measure. Then tell one person what you are working on next — stated commitments survive far better than private ones.

SCORE YOURSELF 1-5

Designing a talk

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Delivery and rehearsal

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Managing nerves

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Impromptu speaking

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

Handling questions

1	2	3	4	5
---	---	---	---	---

IF YOU ARE STILL STRUGGLING

If you did not manage the capstone talk, do not treat the course as unfinished — treat it as scheduled.

Book a five-minute slot in a team meeting within the next two weeks. The skill exists; what is missing is the appointment.

APPENDIX A

The Phrase Bank

Language you can borrow verbatim until your own version arrives. Say these aloud a few times before you need them — a phrase you have never spoken will not come out under pressure. Adapt the wording to your own voice; keep the structure.

Buying time to think

USE THESE INSTEAD OF FILLER

- | *"That is a good question. Give me a second."*
- | *"I want to give you a proper answer rather than a fast one."*
- | *"Let me put that in order before I answer."*
- | *"Can I come back to you on that this afternoon? I would rather check than guess."*

Checking you understood

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"So what I am hearing is ... have I got that right?"*
- | *"Let me play that back: ..."*
- | *"The part I want to be sure about is ..."*
- | *"Is the real issue the cost, or the fact that nobody asked you?"*

Opening a conversation with a stranger

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Longer queue than I expected — have you been to one of these before?"*
- | *"I do not know anybody here yet. Mind if I join you?"*
- | *"What brought you along to this one?"*
- | *"I came mostly for the second talk. What about you?"*

Going one layer deeper

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"How did you end up doing that?"*
- | *"What is the hardest part of it?"*
- | *"You said it was mostly fine — what was the part that was not?"*
- | *"What would you do if it were entirely your call?"*
- | *"What are you hoping to do next year that you have not managed yet?"*

Leaving a conversation

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I am glad we talked — the point about pricing will stay with me. I am going to find the coffee."*
- | *"I need to let you go. Before I do: who else here should I be talking to?"*
- | *"Can I message you about that next week?"*

Recovering a forgotten name

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Sorry, I did not catch your name."*
- | *"Say it again for me? I want to get it right."*
- | *"I have completely lost your name and I would rather ask than guess."*

Saying no, and the conditional yes

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I cannot take that on this month without dropping something else."*
- | *"No to Thursday, but yes to the following week if that still helps."*
- | *"Yes, if the report moves to the twentieth. Otherwise I cannot do both properly."*
- | *"If it is more important than the audit, I will swap them — your call."*
- | *"I am not able to. I can suggest someone who might be."*

Interrupting, and being interrupted

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Let me pause you there — I want Ana's view before we run out of time."*
- | *"Can I jump in? One thing before we move on."*
- | *"I would like to finish the thought, then I want to hear yours."*
- | *"I was not quite done — thirty seconds and it is yours."*

Raising a problem

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Can we talk about the handover? I want it to work well, and at the moment it is causing problems downstream."*
- | *"The last three reports arrived after the deadline. I have been rewriting them at night, and I am frustrated. I need them by Thursday midday."*
- | *"When I did not hear back for three days I assumed it was not a priority. Was that right?"*
- | *"Flagging early: this is not a problem yet, but I want you to know now rather than in two weeks."*

Disagreeing

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I can see why that is attractive, and I disagree — here is where I think it breaks."*
- | *"If we optimise for the launch date, A wins. If for support cost, B wins. Which are we optimising for?"*
- | *"I would change my mind if we could get written confirmation by Friday. Can we?"*
- | *"What am I missing?"*

When you are provoked

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I want to think before I answer."*
- | *"I am finding this difficult and I would rather not say something I regret. Can we pick it up after lunch?"*
- | *"I need twenty minutes. I will come back at three."*
- | *"Help me understand what is behind that."*

Apologising

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"I got that wrong. I committed you to a date without checking, and you worked the weekend because of it."*
- | *"That was not fair, and it was mine. From now on I will confirm with you first."*
- | *"No excuse — I should have told you on Monday."*

Giving feedback

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Can I give you one thing from yesterday? It is small and specific."*
- | *"In the call you answered twice before Ana had finished. She stopped contributing. Next time, hold your answer until she is done."*
- | *"How do you think that went? ... And what would you do differently?"*

Receiving feedback

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Can you give me an example so I know what to watch for?"*
- | *"That is hard to hear and I think it is fair."*
- | *"Thank you for telling me. I want to think about it properly rather than react now."*

Hard questions and objections

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"Fair challenge. Short answer: we tested at half that volume and it held. Above that, we do not know."*
- | *"I do not know. I would rather tell you that than guess. I will have an answer by Thursday."*

- | *"Does that answer it, or do you want the detail?"*
- | *"That is a bigger discussion than we have time for — can we take it after?"*

Negotiating

SAY IT LIKE THIS

- | *"What is driving that date? If I understand the constraint I can probably work with it."*
- | *"I can do the earlier date if we drop the second review. Which would you prefer?"*
- | *"That does not work for me. Here is what would."*

APPENDIX B

Sixty Conversation Starters

Grouped by setting. None of them are clever, and that is the point — a good opener is easy to answer. Pick five, learn them, and use them until they are automatic.

At work, with someone you barely know

- What are you working on at the moment?
- How long have you been here?
- What did you do before this?
- Which part of your job would surprise people?
- Who should I be talking to about this?
- What is the busiest time of year for your team?
- How did you end up in this field?
- What is the thing everyone gets wrong about your work?
- What would you fix first if it were up to you?
- Is it always this busy, or have I picked a bad week?

At an event or conference

- What brought you along to this one?
- Have you been to one of these before?
- Which session are you most looking forward to?
- Anything worth catching that I have missed?
- How far did you have to travel?
- Do you know many people here?
- What are you hoping to get out of today?
- Was the morning session any good?
- Who else here should I meet?
- What made you pick this over the other track?

With a colleague you know slightly

- How was your weekend — anything good?
- What are you working on that you actually enjoy?
- Have you got anything planned for the summer?
- How is the new system treating you?
- What is taking up most of your week?
- Did you get anywhere with that problem from last month?
- Are you still doing the running thing?
- What is the best thing you have read lately?
- How is the team looking after the changes?

- Do you actually get a lunch break in your role?

Socially, with a stranger

- How do you know the host?
- Have you tried the food yet — what is worth having?
- Are you local, or did you travel in?
- What do you do when you are not doing this?
- How long have you lived around here?
- What is the best thing about this neighbourhood?
- Any recommendations for someone new to the area?
- What have you got coming up that you are looking forward to?
- Did you grow up nearby?
- What would you be doing tonight if you were not here?

Going deeper, once it is warm

- What is the best decision you made in the last year?
- What are you learning at the moment?
- What would you do differently if you started again?
- What is something you have changed your mind about?
- What is the part of your job you would keep if you left?
- Who taught you the most, and what did they teach you?
- What is the thing you keep meaning to start?
- What is worth spending money on that most people would not?
- What did you want to be doing at twenty?
- What is the hardest thing you have learned to do?

Reviving a dormant contact

- We talked about the tender process last year — how did that turn out?
- This made me think of you.
- Are you still at the same place?
- I owe you a reply from about a year ago. How are things?
- You mentioned you were learning to sail — how is that going?
- I am working on something you would have an opinion about.
- No agenda — just realised it had been a year.
- Did you ever get that project off the ground?
- Are you going to be at the conference this year?
- Can I pick your brain about something for twenty minutes?

APPENDIX C

Written Templates

Skeletons for the messages you send most often. Replace the square brackets, delete anything you do not need, and read it aloud once before sending.

Request with a decision needed

TEMPLATE

Subject: Decision needed: [thing] by [date]

Hi [name] — I need one decision from you: [option A] or [option B].

Context in three lines: [what changed]. [why it matters]. [what happens if we do nothing].

My recommendation is [A], because [one reason]. A one-word reply is fine. I need it by [date] because [real constraint].

Weekly status update

TEMPLATE

Status: [on track / at risk / blocked / done]

Progress: [two outcomes that are now true and were not last week]

Next: [the two things happening this week]

Blockers: [what is stopping progress, and who can clear it]

Ask: [one specific request, or “nothing needed”]

Meeting recap

TEMPLATE

Decisions: [what was decided]

Actions: [name] does [thing] by [date]. [name] does [thing] by [date].

Open: [what was not resolved, and who will pick it up]

Corrections to me by [time tomorrow], otherwise I will assume this is right.

Following up after meeting someone

TEMPLATE

Hi [name] — we talked at [event] about [specific topic]. You mentioned [the specific thing they said]; [the thing you are sending] is what I was trying to remember.

No need to reply — just thought it might be useful. If you ever want to compare notes on [shared topic], I am always up for it.

Chasing something, without friction

TEMPLATE

Hi [name] — nudging this one, and I know you have had a busy week. I need [specific thing] to [consequence]. If it is not going to happen by [date], tell me and I will [alternative].

Declining

TEMPLATE

Thanks for asking me — I can see why it matters. I cannot take it on [timeframe]; I have [honest reason, one line].

What I can do is [smaller offer], or [person] may have capacity. If this is more important than [current priority], tell me and I will swap them.

Apology

TEMPLATE

I got this wrong: [exactly what you did]. That meant [the effect on them, in their terms].

No excuse. From now on I will [specific change]. If there is anything I can do to put it right, tell me.

Asking for feedback

TEMPLATE

Can I ask you something specific? What is one thing I could do better in [meetings / my updates / how I run this]? I am not fishing for reassurance — one concrete example is more useful to me than a general answer.

APPENDIX D

Meeting Language Toolkit

The sentences that make meetings work, sorted by what you are trying to do. Most of them belong to whoever is willing to say them, not to whoever is chairing.

Open with purpose	"Purpose: we need to choose between the two suppliers. Twenty minutes: ten on trade-offs, five on the decision, five on next steps."
Get in early	"Can I check one thing before we move on — are we assuming the budget is confirmed?"
Build on someone	"Adding to what Sam said — the same applies to renewals."
Bring in a quiet person	"Priya, you have done this before. What are we missing?"
Slow a dominant voice	"Let me pause you there — I want to hear Ana before we run out of time."
Name the confusion	"I think we are talking about two different problems. Can we separate them?"
Surface the assumption	"What are we assuming here that we have not verified?"
Force the decision	"What would we need to know to decide this today?"
Park it honestly	"We are not going to resolve this now. I will take it offline with Jon and come back Thursday."
Protect the quiet dissenter	"Before we agree — is anyone uneasy about this? I would rather hear it now."
Define done	"What does <i>done</i> look like for this, and who decides?"
Assign clearly	"Who owns that, and by when?"
Close it	"So: we decided X. Ana does Y by Friday, I do Z by Monday. Still open: the training question. Anything I have missed?"
Handle the overrun	"We have five minutes and two topics. I suggest we do the decision and move the update to email."
Decline the meeting	"I do not think I am needed for this one — send me the notes and pull me in if the scope changes."

Running a meeting: the four-minute preparation

1. Write the purpose in one sentence, and the decision needed.
2. Write the time plan: how many minutes on what.
3. List who must be there and why. Everyone else gets the notes.
4. Send purpose, decision and time plan in advance — two lines is enough.
5. Reserve the last two minutes for the closing summary, and protect them.

The five sentences that fix most meetings

- **“What decision do we need by the end of this?”** Asked at the start, it saves half the meeting.
- **“Who owns that, and by when?”** The difference between a discussion and a plan.
- **“What are we assuming?”** Surfaces the thing that later goes wrong.
- **“Is anyone uneasy about this?”** Buys you the objection now rather than the failure later.
- **“Let me summarise where we are.”** Available to anyone, and it makes you the most useful person in the room.

If you are the most junior person present

- Ask a clarifying question in the first ten minutes. It is low risk and it establishes that you speak.
- Offer to take the notes and send the recap. It gives you a legitimate voice in what was agreed.
- Bring one prepared point. Preparation, not seniority, is what makes a contribution land.
- If you are talked over, return once: “I would like to finish the thought.” Once is enough to change the pattern.

Virtual meeting specifics

- Signpost more than feels necessary; you cannot read the room.
- Stop every five minutes and ask a direct question to a named person.
- Use the chat deliberately for links, decisions and names — not for a parallel conversation.
- Say who you are handing to: “That is me. Ana, over to you.” Turn-taking online has no body language to rely on.

APPENDIX E

The Frameworks at a Glance

Every structure used in this course, on two pages, for when you need one in a hurry.

Intent sentence	<i>After this, [person] knows / feels / does [what].</i> Write it before you speak. Day 2.
Four message layers	Content, self-disclosure, relationship, appeal. When a message misfires, it is rarely the content. Day 3.
Four levels of listening	Ignoring, waiting, understanding, empathic. Ask which level you are on. Day 12.
Paraphrase	"So what I am hearing is ... have I got that right?" Before you disagree. Day 13.
FORD	Family, Occupation, Recreation, Dreams. Small-talk territories. Day 52.
Headline first (BLUF)	Conclusion in sentence one, then reasons in descending order. Day 41.
PREP	Point, Reason, Example, Point. Any answer in sixty seconds. Day 42.
Rule of three	Announce three, deliver three. Day 43.
Signposting	Map, transitions, importance flags, closing loop. Day 46.
STAR	Situation, Task, Action, Result. Behavioural stories in ninety seconds. Day 49.
Thirty-second version	Who it is for, what problem, what you are doing, where it is now. Day 50.
Status update	Status word, progress, next, blockers, ask. Day 66.
Recap	Decisions, actions with owners and dates, open questions. Day 67.
Feedback	Behaviour, effect, request. Observable, recent, forward-looking. Day 75.
Receiving feedback	Pause, ask for an example, thank them, decide later. Day 76.
Saying no	Acknowledge, decline, offer. Or the conditional yes. Day 77.
Escalation	Issue, impact, two options, recommendation, what you need. Day 78.
Assertive frame	"I need X. I can do Y. I cannot do Z." Day 81.
Difficult opening	Request the conversation, state intention, describe facts, ask a question. Day 82.
DESC	Describe, Express, Specify, Consequences. Day 83.
Observation vs judgement	What a camera recorded, versus what you concluded. Day 84.

Three appeals	Credibility, logic, feeling. Add the one you neglect. Day 88.
Objection handling	Acknowledge, answer briefly, check it landed. Day 89.
Negotiation prep	Ideal, minimum, alternative. Trade, do not concede. Day 90.
Talk design	One message, three points, designed open and close. Day 91.
Impromptu	PREP, or Past-Present-Future, or Problem-Solution-Benefit. Day 97.

APPENDIX F

Self-Assessment: Day 1 and Day 100

Score yourself out of ten in each area on Day 1, and again on Day 100. Do not look at your first scores before writing the second set. The gap is the course; the remaining low scores are your next hundred days.

The eight areas

Listening	I hold my response, paraphrase, and go past the first answer.
Clarity	People understand me the first time, without asking me to repeat.
Brevity	I answer in one breath and stop, without over-explaining.
Voice	My pace, volume, pitch and endings support what I am saying.
Body language	My posture, face and hands match my message.
Small talk	I can start, sustain and leave a conversation with a stranger.
Writing	My messages lead with the point and make the ask explicit.
Difficult conversations	I can raise problems and disagree without damage.

Score sheet

Write the date, then a number out of ten for each area.

Date	_____ Day 1 / Day 100 (circle one)
Listening	____ / 10 Clarity ____ / 10
Brevity	____ / 10 Voice ____ / 10
Body language	____ / 10 Small talk ____ / 10
Writing	____ / 10 Difficult conversations ____ / 10
Total	____ / 80

The recording comparison

Record sixty seconds answering “*What do you do, and what are you working on right now?*” on Day 1 and again on Day 100. Listen to them back to back, and write what you hear.

Pace	Day 1: _____ Day 100: _____
Fillers per minute	Day 1: _____ Day 100: _____
Longest sentence	Day 1: _____ Day 100: _____
Clear point?	Day 1: _____ Day 100: _____
Ending	Day 1: _____ Day 100: _____

Three audible differences

Not “I sounded better.” Write three things a stranger could verify by listening to both recordings.

My next two skills, and the weekly drill for each

Choose by cost to you, not by interest. Name the drill and the day of the week you will do it.

The date I will re-measure

Put it in your calendar now, not later. Ninety days from today is the usual choice.

APPENDIX G

Drill Library and Practice Partners

Reusable drills for after Day 100, and instructions you can hand to a practice partner who has not read the book.

Solo drills, five to ten minutes

- **Read aloud.** Three hundred words of good prose. Rotate the focus: breath at punctuation, final consonants, one stressed word per sentence, pace variation.
- **The one-minute answer.** Pick a random question, take two seconds, answer in PREP for sixty seconds. Record one in five.
- **Filler count.** Two minutes explaining anything. Count the fillers. Repeat once, replacing each with a pause.
- **Headline drill.** Take five emails in your sent folder and rewrite the first line of each as a headline.
- **Half-length edit.** Take a paragraph you wrote and cut it by fifty percent without losing meaning.
- **Mirror greeting.** Eyebrow raise, eye contact, genuine smile, opening line. Ten repetitions.
- **Impromptu five.** Five random topics, ninety seconds each, one of the three structures. Recorded.
- **Voice warm-up.** Breath, body, hum, tongue twisters. Five minutes before anything that matters.

Real-world drills, no extra time required

- **Two strangers a day.** Thirty seconds each. Shop, lift, queue, corridor.
- **One paraphrase per meeting.** Before you add your own view.
- **Three-second gaps.** Leave three seconds after the other person stops, five times a day.
- **One recap.** After every meeting that had actions in it.
- **One question you were avoiding.** Weekly.
- **One assertive sentence.** Daily, however small.
- **Speak in the first ten minutes.** Every meeting, no exceptions.

For your practice partner

Hand this section to whoever is helping you. Ten minutes a week is enough.

1. **Two-minute listening test.** Talk to them about a real problem for two minutes. They may only nod. Afterwards they tell you the three main points they heard. You check their accuracy — this trains them and tests you.
2. **Question interview.** They ask you five questions about your work. You answer each in under sixty seconds, in PREP. They tell you which answer was longest and which was clearest.
3. **Hostile questioner.** They pick your five hardest questions and ask them rapidly, in a slightly cold tone. You practise acknowledge, answer briefly, check.
4. **Difficult conversation role-play.** You have prepared a DESC script. They play the other person and push back once, then agree. You practise not abandoning the request.
5. **One honest observation.** At the end, they give you one thing they noticed: filler words, pace, eye contact, hedging, length. One thing only — not a list.

The three habits to keep forever

- **The two-second pause** before answering anything important. It buys thinking time and reads as composure.
- **The one-sentence intent** before anything that matters. Eight seconds of thought that removes most rambling.
- **The weekly sixty-second recording.** The only honest feedback available for free, and the only reliable defence against quiet decay.

A note on what this course does not cover

Communication skills will not fix a bullying manager, an unsafe workplace, a discriminatory process or a relationship in crisis. If you are in one of those situations, the right tools are HR, a union representative, a lawyer, a doctor or a therapist — not a better script. Being able to speak clearly helps you use those channels, but it is not a substitute for them.

Day 101

Nobody finishes learning this. The point of a hundred days is not mastery; it is a set of habits that keep improving on their own because you now notice what you are doing.

Keep three things: the pause, the one-sentence intent, and the weekly recording. Those three will carry the rest.

Then pick the two skills that still cost you the most, and give them the next hundred days.